

SC questions parliam^{ent}'s power to slap super tax

By Nasir Iqbal

ISLAMABAD: Justice Jamal Khan Mandokhail, a member of the five-judge Supreme Court constitutional bench, on Tuesday questioned whether the National Assembly could be granted specific authority under the constitution to enact tax legislation that operates outside the financial year.

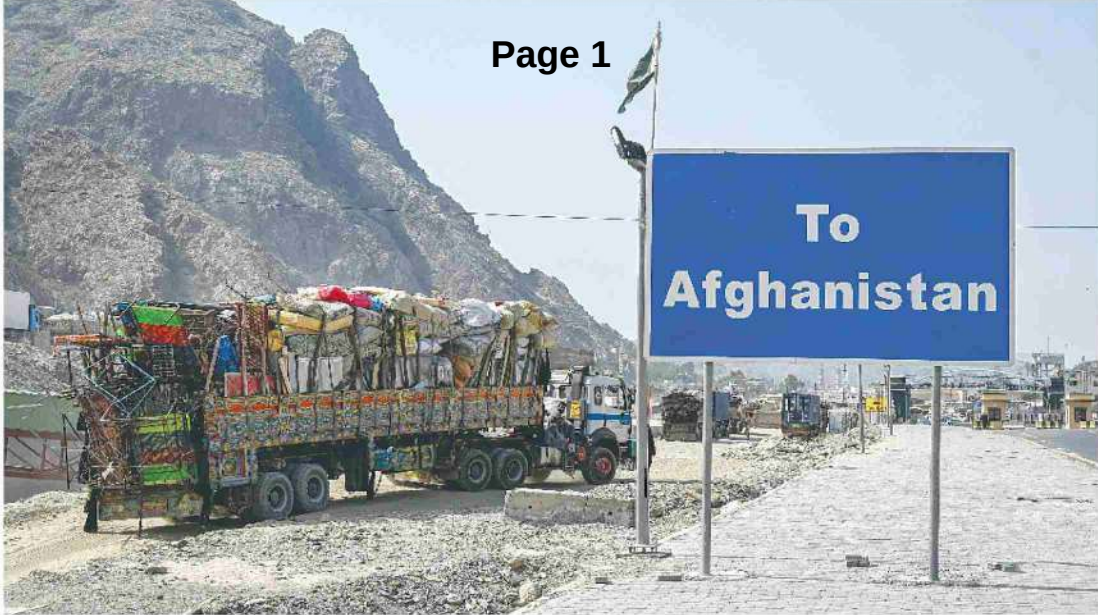
Headed by Justice Aminuddin Khan, the CB was hearing multiple petitions filed by taxpayers challenging the constitutional vires of the amended Section 4C of the Income Tax Ordinance (ITO), 2001, applicable to the tax year 2023.

However, senior counsel Hafiz Ehsaan Ahmad Khokhar, representing the Federal Board of Revenue (FBR), argued that the present case did not involve any question of the National Assembly's legislative competence.

During the hearing, Additional Attorney General Chaudhry Aamir Rehman informed the court that the federal government would submit a written response within a few days.

On April 4, 2024, a division bench of the

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TORKHAM: Trucks laden with Afghan refugees' belongings arrive at the main border crossing between Pakistan and Afghanistan. According to IOM, over 112,000 Afghans returned to their country in the last week of August.—AFP

US official calls on Islamabad to engage with Afghan Taliban

Imran echoes Khalilzad's views, terms dialogue with Kabul only way to achieve lasting peace

By Ikram Junaidi

ISLAMABAD: Days after Pakistan asked the Afghan Taliban to choose whether they want to stand with their neighbour, or the outlawed Tehreek-i-Taliban Pakistan (TTP) militant group, a key US official has called on Islamabad to seek a political settlement with Kabul.

Zalmay Khalilzad, who was named US special rep-

resentative to Afghanistan during the previous Trump administration, also called on Afghanistan to "help Pakistan with such negotiations".

The former diplomat recently undertook a visit to Kabul alongside US hostage envoy Adam Boehler, where he met with key members of the Afghan Taliban regime.

In a tweet posted after he wrapped up his visit, Khalilzad noted that violence between Pakistan's security forces and the TTP had resulted in the deaths of a significant number of security personnel and citizens.

Saying that he believed pursuing a military solution to this challenge was a mistake, he called on Islamabad to "shift to a political strat-

egy and negotiate".

"The Pakistani establishment always advised the US and Afghan government before 2021 to negotiate and seek a political settlement with the Afghan Taliban. The time has come for Pakistan to consider doing the same," he said.

The timing of the message is significant, as it comes just days after PM Shehbaz Sharif and Field Marshal Asim Munir gave Kabul a stark choice.

"I want to give a clear message to Afghanistan to choose between Pakistan and TTP," PM Shehbaz had said during a visit to Bannu alongside the army chief.

Although President Trump and US military officials such as CENTCOM chief Gen Michael Kurilla

have repeatedly praised Pakistan's counterterrorism cooperation — with the arrest of IS-Khorasan operative who targeted the Kabul airport's Abbey Gate in 2021 being a highlight — Khalilzad's message seems to be the first indication that the US wants both Islamabad and Kabul to come to the table.

In Washington circles, Khalilzad is viewed as a hawk. He openly sympathises with jailed PTI founder Imran Khan and has—in the past—reserved critical words for Pakistan.

In a tweet posted just last month, he claimed that Afghanistan's successful operations against IS-Khorasan had pushed

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Punjab's wheat restrictions trigger domino effect

- Despite official denials, checkpoints set up at province's exit points to curtail movement
- Flour prices in KP jump 68pc; 20kg bag hits Rs2,800
- KP Assembly passes unanimous resolution against Punjab's move

By Amjad Mahmood

LAHORE: Punjab's unannounced ban on the interprovincial movement of wheat has ignited a new crisis, causing a severe flour shortage and soaring prices in other provinces. The move has drawn sharp criticism from politicians and flour millers who argue it violates constitutional rights and a recent deregulation agreement.

While Punjab officials denied a formal ban, they acknowledged establish-

ing checkpoints to curb what they termed "unusual" wheat movement. Critics, however, argued that these measures are against the spirit of a deregulated market.

The ban has been met with strong condemnation from other provinces, particularly Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and Sindh, which heavily depend on Punjab's wheat supply.

The All-Pakistan Flour Mills Association (PFMA) has labelled the policy unconstitutional, citing Article 151 of the Constitution, which guaran-

tees the freedom of trade and commerce across the country.

According to Riazullah Khan, chairman of the Punjab Flour Mills Association, checkpoints at the province's exit points are blocking the transport of wheat and flour to other regions. He said that these actions run counter to the deregulation policy, which promised unrestricted trade and movement of wheat.

As a result of the restrictions, flour

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PTA chairman's appointment declared unlawful

Page 1

- Islamabad High Court rules govt exceeded its mandate in creating new post, advertised job before required legislation was enacted
- Directs govt to ensure fairness in appointments
- Retired Maj Gen Hafeezur Rehman challenges decision through intra-court appeal

By Malik Asad

ISLAMABAD: The Islamabad High Court (IHC) on Tuesday declared the creation of the post of member (administration) in the Pakistan Telecommunication Authority (PTA) and the subsequent appointment of retired Maj Gen Hafeezur Rehman as PTA chairman “unconstitutional, illegal and void ab initio”.

The decision, however, was challenged by the PTA chairman hours after it was announced.

In a detailed judgement, authored by Justice Babar Sattar on writ petition (No. 1561 of 2023), the court ruled that the federal government had exceeded its mandate under the Pakistan Telecommunication (Re-Organisation) Act, 1996 by creating the post of member (administration) without the necessary amendments to the law.

The judgement pointed out that the advertisement for the post,

issued on March 28, 2023, had been published at a time when no such position legally existed. Later, amendments to the PTA Appointment Rules in May 2023 were deemed insufficient to regularise the appointment process.

Justice Sattar observed that the recruitment process “suffered from malice in law” and appeared to have been tailored to accommodate a specific individual. The prescription of a higher age limit of 61 years for the post, compared with 57 years for other members, was cited as further proof of mala fide intent.

Appointment ‘unsustainable’

The court further held that the appointment of the retired army officer as PTA chairman, without a transparent and objective selection process, was “illegal, irrational and unsustainable in the eyes of law”.

As a result, the IHC ordered

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Pakistan signals support for united anti-Israel front

Page 1

• ‘Why not’, says Dar when asked about possibility of combined security force in Middle East • PM meets Qatari emir, Iranian president on sidelines of Doha summit

Dawn Report

KARACHI: Deputy Prime Minister Ishaq Dar hinted at the possibility of joining a proposed unified front against Israel, if such a move came to fruition.

Pakistan has “very large” and “effective” armed forces that

Pakistan sees ‘dangerous escalation’; UNHRC urges accountability for Israel’s Qatar attack: Page 11

have proven their capabilities in conventional warfare, Mr Dar, who also holds the foreign affairs portfolio, said during an interview with *Al Jazeera*.

He was responding to a question

about the possible position Islamabad would take in case a united body was formed in the Middle East to stop Israeli aggression.

When asked if the formation of such a body — away from the United Nations structure — to intervene in Gaza was one of the options on the table, Mr Dar said that a mechanism could be chalked out.

He mentioned that there had been talk along the lines of “some sort of combined security force” during recent interactions among Arab nations and the Arab League.

“Why not? What’s wrong with that? They should [have a combined force]. And according to their own capacity, own strength, they should create some mechanism. Not for aggression purpose

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Monitoring unit's report a damning indictment on cardiac care at PIC

Report exposes mismanagement, mentioning names of patients

By Asif Chaudhry

LAHORE: The Chief Minister's Special Monitoring Unit (SMU) has issued a report on the Punjab Institute of Cardiology (PIC), Lahore, pointing out gross mismanagement, criminal negligence in the treatment of the heart attack and other patients and those waiting for bypass, besides exposing other grave systematic failures.

In its 22-page report, the SMU highlighted the scale of sufferings of the heart patients in the biggest public sector cardiac institute of the province.

"The SMU conducted an unannounced follow-up visit at the PIC, Lahore, and revealed systemic administrative collapse and medical negligence," reads the report.

It has declared that the hospital is failing in its core responsibility of delivering timely, safe, and adequate cardiac care. (a copy of the report is also available with *Dawn*).

As per the report, the inspection exposed grave systemic failures: essential medicines were missing, diagnostics and interventions dangerously delayed, and critical infrastructure like CCUs and lifts left non-functional.

Staff negligence and misconduct, coupled with a broken Hospital Management Information System (HMIS) and severe lapses in hygiene and patient safety,

have put lives at risk, it declared adding that immediate corrective action and strict accountability are imperative.

Raising a core issue of the long queues outside OPD pharmacy, the SMU lamented that patients were redirected to indoor pharmacy and sent back without help while the prescribed medicines were not available in both indoor and emergency pharmacies.

It stated that post-bypass medicines were withheld due to non-preparation of slips, declaring it a reckless administrative lapse.

"Model pharmacy in emergency failed to provide essential medicines and patients were not guided on alternative salts," reads the report adding that the SMU inspection team has provided some proofs with the profiles of some patients who were denied prescribed medicines.

The SMU said the hospital staff was charging Rs2,000 for delivering urgent CDs of their surgeries instead of Rs1,500 while the patients who were unable to pay urgent fee were forced to wait for three months or so, declaring it a clear case of exploitation.

The pharmacy staff's behaviour was reported as rude, dismissive, and hostile with the cardiac patients and their attendants.

There were no temperature/humidity meters in the OPD pharmacy and the installation of one AC there was posing potential risks of damage to medicines.

The SMU also declared the 'medicine home delivery service' a failed scheme saying the cardiac patients were forced to visit the PIC to collect the same.

"A patient Muhammad Rafique, reported that he did not receive his medicines at home for the last 2-3 months. He is

forced to personally visit PIC every month to collect medicines", reads the report.

The report alleges that the pharmacists were observed distributing medicines partially instead of the full prescribed quantity.

It highlighted the cases of six such patients who were provided incomplete medicines by the pharmacists.

"During SMU's visit, pharmacist Ms. Mahnoor (In-charge OPD Pharmacy) was absent from duty while the other pharmacy staff had no information about available stock and directed the SMU to the AMS. This is a clear dereliction of duty by the In-charge," reads the report.

While shedding light on the mismanagement in diagnostic services and extreme delays, the SMU lamented that prolonged echocardiography waiting time has extended to a month period and declared this practice dangerous for critical cardiac patients. Similarly, it said, the ultrasound waiting time [3/4 days] was being repeatedly rescheduled besides highlighting the mismanagement in the X-Ray, CT Scan, OPD and ECHO departments.

Medical representatives were found roaming in corridors near ECHO desk in blatant violation of the laid down SoPs while there was only one bed available in ECG room which was causing delays in urgent admissions from emergency.

The SMU pointed out that only one doctor was on duty in the emergency room to examine new arrivals – risking crucial minutes of life-saving care.

The air conditioning was non-functional across wards, CCUs, waiting areas, CT Scan and X-Ray rooms.

Out of the two lifts installed in the Emergency Block, one was functional, cre-

ating delays in shifting critical patients.

There was only one wheelchair without a pedal available, leaving the cardiac patients in grave distress while the bed sheets in wards were in the worst condition.

A patient was forced to bring his personal pulse oximeter as no cardiac monitor was available on the third floor of the hospital.

The SMU report pointed out another negligence stating no oxygen flow meters were attached to the beds.

About the common complaints, it said, a heart patient (Amir) was left unattended for two hours or so as no doctor was available in the emergency ward while the angiography of a heart attack patient (Ijaz) brought from Gujranwala was delayed over 24 hours.

The bypass of a patient (Fayyaz Ali) was not performed 22 days after his admission.

A heart patient (Sohail Muneer) was brought to the PIC following the serious complaints of leakage of his valve due to negligence at multiple hospitals. His dental clearance test was lost by the PIC sweeper and the doctors discharged the patient without surgery.

"The medical form of a patient, Rehana (Bed 17, 3rd floor), had contradictory entries "Yes" and "No" (ticked for diabetes) which was a high-risk blunder before operation," reads the SMU report.

The doctors were found using mobile phones inside offices during duty while patients were waiting.

Similarly, the nursing staff members in emergency ICU/HDU were also found busy on phones, ignoring critical patients.

Agent arrested for trafficking in the guise of football teams

Page 2

GUJRAT: The Federal Investigation Agency (FIA) Gujranwala Zone claims to have arrested a human trafficking agent involved in sending illegal immigrants to Japan as football players using fake credentials and certificates.

A senior FIA official said that suspect Waqas Ali, a resident of Pasroor, Sialkot, was arrested in a case on Sept 15.

The official said the suspect, with the connivance of 17 immigrants, managed to get 15-day visit visas of Japan on the invitation of Boavista Football Club. The official claimed that he used forged Pakistan Football Federation registration letter and a fake NOC from the Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

The official claimed that the suspect extorted Rs4 to 4.5 million from each of the 17 persons. He said that they travelled to Japan on Jan 1, 2024, and never returned.

FIA Gujranwala Director Muhammad Bin Ashraf told *Dawn* that a case had been registered against the suspect and further investigation was ongoing.

The suspect was also nominated in another similar case at FIA Gujranwala circle for sending a 22-member fake football team to Japan on June 15, 2025. However, the group was deported by the Japanese immigration authorities from the airport and the matter was then reported to the FIA.

The FIA launched an inquiry and finally arrested the suspect and registered cases against him. — **Correspondent**

Theft in house of a flood-hit man

Page 2

BAHAWALPUR: Thieves allegedly took away valuables from the house of a man displaced by the recent flood in Fateh Shah area of the Vehari district.

According to police, Iqbal, of Fateh Shah area, had to evacuate with his family because of the floodwaters, leaving his belongings in his house. On Tuesday, some thieves took away a fodder-cutting machine, a motorcycle and other valuables from his house. — Correspondent

PR for strict observation of safety protocols

Page 2

LAHORE: A new Pakistan Railway's (PR) report has revealed that in the first half of 2025, a total of 61 accidents occurred across its network and the situation forced the authorities to intensify the safety protocols to ensure safe trains operation.

A safety directorate has also been established at the PR's headquarters in Lahore to deal with safety of passengers, crew and officials during journeys, *Dawn* has learnt.

The report, titled "Special Bulletin", sought strict compliance of relevant rules and regulations by the officers / officials working in the operations wing — the biggest department of PR.

"During this year (Jan 1 to June 26), 61 accidents occurred over the Pakistan Railways network, which were mostly due to poor maintenance of track, rolling stock, signaling & interlocking and specially due to negligent working by the railway staff, despite issuance of repeated instructions for safe train operations," the report states.

"The PR has prime responsibility to ensure safe train operation. The railway officials should comply with the rules / instructions to minimize accidents. The division officers should also adopt all possible preventive measures to avoid recurrence of such accidents," it said.

The report gave several directions and safety measures, especially during the ongoing season as well as flooding in various area.

"All precautionary measures be adopted / ensured to prevent the disaster of flood as per chapter 28 of way and works manual," the report reads.

It further said that the chief duty of the bridge inspector was to carry out bridge repairs and renewals under traffic. In doing this work, the primary consideration should be the safety of trains.

It said, "The bridge inspector must take every precaution to ensure that all the works under his charge are carried out safely and in accordance with the rules". It further sought officials to daily inspect on foot every portion of the permanent way and said that the interval between such inspections could be increased to once in two days in the case of lines with light and traffic. The report also elaborated duties of a keyman, patrolling of the line by gangmates and gangmen during storms and heavy rains, examination of signals, points etc, fixing altering or removing signals, points etc, working of train examiners, railway police. — **Khalid Hasnain**

PPP leaders rap govt's 'slack response' to floods

Azma says allies are just a political compulsion

By Our Staff Reporter

LAHORE: Pakistan People's Party (PPP) leaders Chaudhry Manzoor Ahmed and Syed Hassan Murtaza criticised the government for its "poor response" to the recent floods, demanding an audit of the 2023 floods and alleging delay in the call for international aid.

At a press conference held here on Tuesday, Manzoor stated that the government delayed declaring a flood emergency and appealing for international aid. He said both steps should have been taken during the critical first 72 hours of the calamity.

Referring to Chief Minister Maryam Nawaz's earlier stance that the government would not appeal for international assistance, he highlighted Pakistan's worsening position in the global climate change rankings, moving from third to first spot in terms of vulnerability.

He claimed that the scale of the destruction in Punjab's flood-hit tehsils is so immense that even three provincial budgets would not be enough to compensate for the damage.

Manzoor noted that crops have been buried under several feet of sand in what he called the worst flood in the river Sutlej, which has thrice witnessed a high flow exceeding 350,000 cusecs.

The PPP leaders demanded the government should provide cash assistance to the flood-hit people through the Benazir Income Support Programme (BISP), arguing that this mode of payment would maintain their dignity as they would not have to stand in long queues for receiving aid.

They also demanded that the affected farmers be compensated for their destroyed crops following a

proper survey (Girdawari).

Manzoor also accused the government of attempting to privatise food security institutions like the Zarai Taraqiati Bank, Pakistan Agricultural Storage and Services Corporation (Passco), and Utility Stores Corporation, which had been playing a vital role during the past floods.

Mr Murtaza, while answering the media questions, called the government's announcement to waive off one-month electricity bills for the flood-hit people a "joke," suggesting a minimum of six-month waiver of bills should be announced.

He criticised the government for claiming credit for providing relief to the flood-hit people, instead of providing tangible help to them, saying the affected people "do not want the government's flour and charity."

Comparing the flood management measures taken in Punjab with those in Sindh, he claimed the latter's government was more prepared to handle the calamity due to clearing of encroachments in the waterways.

He highlighted the extensive flood damage in the Jhang district, where sugarcane, maize and paddy crops have been completely destroyed.

Murtaza stressed that the real problems for the flood-hit people are only beginning, and the government must stand by them to help them get back on their feet.

Meanwhile, lashing out at the PPP for its criticism of the Punjab government's handling of the recent flood and the affected people, provincial minister for Information and Culture Azma Bukhari says the PML-N is tolerating its allies just because of "political compulsion".

In Punjab, the PML-N government has three main allies -- the PPP of the Bhuttos, the PML-Q of Chaudhry Shujaat Hussain and the Istehkam-i-

Pakistan Party of Aleem Khan.

"At present, our only focus is on public service. It is due to political compulsion that we are tolerating our allies, but this does not mean we have to listen to the PPP's failed theories and false philosophies," Ms Bokhari said in a statement on Tuesday.

She says the PTI alone is sufficient to cry over its "political unemployment" and there is no need for the PPP to step into this narrative.

Ms Bokhari says the PPP leaders Manzoor Chaudhry and Hassan Murtaza should present their grievances and theories to the PPP Chairman Bilawal Bhutto and Sindh Chief Minister Murad Ali Shah, instead of indulging in political point scoring in Punjab.

She says that Sindh had not suffered any major human or financial losses due to the recent floods, yet the PPP is pressurising the federation to seek foreign aid, which reflected a "non-serious approach."

"The PPP and its defeated leaders must first focus on addressing the problems of the people of Sindh, where victims of the 2022 floods are still waiting for relief," she says.

The minister says Punjab is facing the worst flood in the country's history, adding that the administration in the province is working day and night for the relief and rehabilitation of flood victims.

"The Punjab government is providing all-possible assistance to the [flood] victims from its own resources and has not looked towards the federation or any other organisation for help. CM Maryam has redirected all available resources and government machinery toward the affected areas," the minister says.

President pledges support for Chinese NEVs

Page 3

Witnesses accords on agriculture, mass transit, environment

By Syed Irfan Raza

ISLAMABAD: President Asif Ali Zardari assured a major Chinese car maker on Tuesday that the government would provide policy support for new energy vehicles (NEV), electric buses and local production of components.

In a meeting with Yin Tongyue, the chairman of Chery Automobile Company Ltd, the president encouraged the firm to explore joint ventures in electric buses, mini trucks, green energy solutions and charging infrastructure.

He also highlighted opportunities for collaboration with Pakistani companies in manufacturing, minerals and energy storage solutions.

Mr Yin briefed the president and his delegation on Chery Auto's global



SHANGHAI: President Asif Ali Zardari witnesses the signing of an MoU.—APP

operations, its commitment to technological innovation, and its achievements in international markets.

Meanwhile, Zhu Xiaoping, CEO and Co-founder of SUS Environment Technology, a leading Chinese waste management company, also called on the president.

Discussions focused on urban waste management, waste-to-energy

projects and integrated treatment solutions.

President Zardari underlined Pakistan's need for modern waste management systems, especially in Sindh, and welcomed the prospect of cooperation.

Mr Zhu shared his firm's experience in advanced waste treatment, and expressed an interest in invest-

ing in Pakistan.

In a separate meeting with Chen Jining, secretary of the Communist Party of China (CPC), President Zardari reaffirmed that Pakistan-China ties are unshakeable, saying that while spoilers and hostile elements may try to harm the relationship, they will never succeed.

Chen also briefed the president on Shanghai's transformation. Once a manufacturing hub, the city has become a major centre of the services industry, with significant investments in healthcare and education, resulting in higher life expectancy than other parts of China.

The meeting also discussed opportunities for industrial collaboration in Pakistan's Special Economic Zones and Gwadar Free Zone, particularly in technology, IT, artificial intelligence and innovation.

President Zardari also witnessed the signing of three Memoranda of Understanding to advance Pakistan's agricultural, environmental and mass transit initiatives, in Shanghai, China.

Balochistan launches first financial digital e-filing system

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Citizens will be able to monitor projects and financial records through digital access

By Saleem Shahid

QUETTA: The Balochistan government has introduced the first-ever automated financial digital e-filing system in the province to promote transparency and digital governance.

Chief Minister Mir Sarfraz Bugti launched the digital financial e-filing system at a ceremony held at the Chief Minister Secretariat on Tuesday. Provincial ministers, assembly members and senior officials from various administrative departments attended the event.

The initiative marks a significant step towards modernising public sector operations and providing citizens with direct access to financial and development data.

Speaking at the inauguration, the chief minister said the new system would streamline financial processes, eliminate bureaucratic inefficiencies, and strengthen public oversight.

"The e-filing system is designed to serve as the backbone of comprehensive financial reform across the province," Mr Bugti said, adding that its core features include online budget submissions, with all government departments now required to submit budget requests digitally.

He said the system would assist at every stage of approval, with all financial transactions recorded

and accessible. The aim, he said, is to replace outdated and opaque procedures that have long undermined efficiency.

Officials will have access to live data, enabling faster and better-informed decisions. At the same time, citizens will be able to monitor development projects and financial records on their devices, checking whether initiatives are completed or merely proposed.

"Balochistan is now stepping into the digital age, aligning itself with global standards of transparency and accountability," the chief minister said.

To ensure swift implementation, he directed all departmental secretaries to immediately adopt the system. He also announced that future cabinet meetings would be conducted on digital tablets to avoid delays and phase out paper-based processes.

CM Bugti praised the local officials and IT experts who developed the system, noting that it was built entirely by Balochistan's youth and professionals without external assistance. He also announced a one-month salary bonus for government employees involved in the project and pledged similar incentives for private-sector contributors as a token of appreciation.

Earlier, Finance Secretary Imran Zarkoon gave a detailed briefing and live demonstration of the system's features. The ceremony concluded with the chief minister distributing certificates of appreciation to the development team, reaffirming the government's commitment to the responsible and transparent use of public resources.

17 PTI lawmakers quit Senate panels

Page 3

ISLAMABAD: Seventeen PTI and allied senators sent their resignations from the Senate standing committees to Senate Chairman Yousaf Raza Gilani on Tuesday.

The application, signed by PTI's parliamentary party leader Senator Syed Ali Zafar, said that the decision had been taken voluntarily in solidarity with incarcerated PTI leader Imran Khan.

The senators who quit the panels included Ali Zafar, Azam Swati, Zeeshan Khanzada, Raja Nasir Abbas (MWM), Aon Abbas, Fawzia Arshad, Dost Muhammad, Mohsin Aziz, Humayun Mohmand, Dr Zarqa Suharwardi, Saifullah Khan Nyazee, Falak Naz, Rubina Naz, Mashal Yousafzai, Mirza Muhammad Afridi, Pir Noorul Haq Qadri and Faisal Javed.

Speaking to reporters at Parliament House, Senator Ali Zafar said that resignations of as many as 17 senators were being submitted as Imran Khan instructed him that there was no need to wait for all members. The remaining resignations would be submitted soon, he added.—Staff Reporter

Imaan moves SJC again after removal of woman judge from harassment body

Dawn Report

ISLAMABAD: Advocate Imaan Zainab Mazari-Hazir approached the Supreme Judicial Council (SJC) again on Tuesday, with a complaint against the removal of Justice Saman Rafat Imtiaz as the competent authority regarding workplace harassment at the Islamabad High Court (IHC).

The judge was stripped of her powers by IHC Chief Justice Sarfaraz Dogar, hours after she took cognisance of a complaint against him.

The episode stems from a terse exchange between Justice Dogar and Ms Mazari last week, where the former reportedly used threatening and misogynistic language as he tried to warn her of

contempt proceedings.

A day earlier, Ms Mazari filed a complaint against the top judge before the IHC's workplace harassment committee, and also moved a misconduct reference before the SJC.

After Justice Saman Imtiaz took cognisance of her complaint, the IHC administration de-notified her as the "competent authority" and replaced her with Justice Inaam Ameen Minhas.

In a post on X on Tuesday, Ms Mazari said she had filed an addendum to her initial complaint lodged with the SJC against Justice Dogar following yesterday's "alarming development".

She said Justice Imtiaz was "arbitrarily and with mala fide" removed as the competent authority just a few hours after she had

lodged her complaint and a committee was constituted to inquire into the matter.

Advocate Mazari said the judge had formed a three-member inquiry team, but Chief Justice Dogar, "with clear mala fide and conflict of interest" removed her without giving any reason.

Instead of responding to the complaint, the chief justice used his administrative powers to alter the inquiry body and remove the only woman judge who received her complaint, she maintained.

Separately, a lawyer also filed a reference before the Islamabad Bar Council (IBC), seeking the cancellation of Ms Mazari's licence to practice law, over her alleged involvement in "anti-state activities" and a "smear campaign against state functionaries".

Senate panel seeks briefing on railways' outsourcing policies

Page 3

Senators express disappointment over minister, senior PR officials' absence from meeting

By Amin Ahmed

ISLAMABAD: Matters relating to outsourcing trains, servicing and adopting public-private partnerships by Pakistan Railways were raised during a meeting of the Senate Standing Committee on Railways, which met in Islamabad on Tuesday.

Senator Rubina Khalid, who joined the committee as a member, questioned the procedure and rationale behind adopting models not widely practiced internationally.

The committee asked the Ministry of Railways to provide a thorough briefing on its outsourcing policies and practices in the next meeting.

She also expressed concern over the closure of trains in Khyber Pakhtunkhwa and called for uniform development of railway infrastructure across all provinces.

Committee Chairman Jam Saifullah Khan announced that the next meeting will be held in Peshawar to specifically review railway projects and facilities in the province.

Additionally, Senator Khalid underscored the strategic importance of the Afghan transit trade and stressed that railway access must be extended to Torkham Pass to strengthen regional connectivity.

The committee called for a comprehensive briefing on railway gauges to evaluate which system would best connect Pakistan with neighbouring countries.

Members expressed their disappointment over the absence of the Railways Minister Hanif Abbasi and senior officials, despite prior assurances to ensure compliance.

They noted that the working papers submitted to them were neither complete nor provided 72 hours in advance, as required.

Senator Shahadat Awan said that details of a police report regarding the alleged corruption of billions of rupees were still missing, despite repeated directions from the committee. He termed it highly inappropriate that after 11 meetings,

complete information was still not shared with the committee.

Senator Khalid and Senator Kamil Ali Agha endorsed these concerns, stressing that it was unjustified for members to travel from other cities when the ministry failed to provide relevant data.

The chairman reminded that the minister had earlier assured transparent provision of information and directed that in the next meeting, the minister, secretary, Inspector General and DIG Railways must be present to brief the committee in detail. He further instructed that all future working papers be prepared in properly.

The committee also discussed the flood situation and was informed that while old bridges had largely withstood the impact, some sectors, including Narowal-Sialkot, were temporarily affected but had since been restored.

Senator Awan also raised the issue of restoring Budhal Express train between Rohri and Jacobabad and the Mandra-Chakwal railway line, stressing that people were forced to spend heavily on road travel due to suspension of these services.

Deadlock persists on GB traders' demand for tax exemptions

Page 3

Border remains blocked as traders' sit-in at Sost continues for 50th day

By Jamil Nagri

GILGIT: The prime minister's 22-member committee failed on Tuesday to reach consensus on recommendations for resolving grievances of Gilgit-Baltistan's traders, with the matter deferred to another meeting scheduled for Wednesday.

The committee, formed by Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif to address concerns over taxes and clearance of consignments imported from China via the Khunjerab Pass, met in Islamabad under the chairmanship of Federal Energy Minister Awais Leghari. It was the body's fourth meeting.

The session was attended by federal ministers Rana Sanaullah and Amir Muqam, Attorney General Mansoor Usman Awan, Senator Saleem Mandviwalla, GB Chief Minister Haji Gulbar Khan, GB Assembly member Amjad Hussain Advocate, and representatives from the NLC, FBR, MI, IB, FIA and ISI.

Tax-free zone

Sources said the GB chief minister

and Amjad Hussain Advocate pressed for declaring Gilgit-Baltistan a tax-free zone and allowing residents to import unlimited items from China for local consumption. Mr Khan argued that as GB was a non-tariff area, the collection of federal taxes was unjustified.

However, Senator Mandviwalla opposed the proposal for unlimited imports, while objections were also raised over the mechanism to exempt GB residents from income tax and other federal levies.

Mr Hussain told *Dawn* that committee members from GB also sought urgent clearance of consignments stuck at Sost Dry Port for the past 10 months, which have caused traders billions in losses.

The meeting ended in deadlock over the mechanism for imports and exemptions. Sources said the committee would reconvene in Islamabad on Wednesday (today) to try to bridge differences and present unified recommendations to the prime minister.

Earlier, the GB cabinet, after consultations with protesting traders, submitted proposals recommending that prior permission from the GB government be mandatory for imports intended for local consumption. It also called for reassessment of perishable goods stuck at Sost to

allow depreciation relief under the prime minister's amnesty scheme.

The cabinet also suggested exempting local traders from all federal taxes — including income tax, sales tax, federal excise duty and regulatory duty — on goods sold in GB markets, but imposing full duties and taxes on consignments transported outside the region.

Meanwhile, opposition members in the GB Assembly staged a walkout on Monday after their resolution on traders' issues was not tabled despite being on the agenda. The resolution demanded that GB be declared a tax-free zone. Speaker Nazir Ahmed said the quorum had not been met, prompting members to stage a walkout in protest.

Sit-in enters 50th day

At Sost, traders' sit-in entered its 50th consecutive day on Monday, blocking the Karakoram Highway and suspending cross-border trade with China. Immigration offices and border entry and exit points also remained closed.

The blockade has stranded hundreds, including Chinese nationals, foreign tourists and Pakistani students enrolled in Chinese universities. Although immigration was briefly opened on Thursday, it was closed again the next day.

IHC bars Justice Jahangiri from judicial work

Page 4

Division bench raises questions about validity of judge's degree

By Malik Asad

ISLAMABAD: In an extraordinary development on Tuesday, the Islamabad High Court (IHC) restrained senior judge Justice Tariq Mehmood Jahangiri from exercising his judicial powers, after a division bench raised serious questions about the validity of his law degree from the University of Karachi.

The two-judge bench, headed by Chief Justice Mohammad Sarfraz Dogar and comprising Justice Mohammad Azam Khan, issued the interim order while hearing a writ petition filed by lawyer Mian Dawood under Article 199 of the Constitution. The petition seeks a writ of quo warranto, questioning "by what authority" Justice Jahangiri holds judicial office.

"The office has raised certain objections. This Court is of the view that the same would be seen on the judicial side at the time of

final adjudication of instant case," the court order stated.

It further said: "It has been noted that a writ of quo warranto under Article 199(1)(b)(ii) of the Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Pakistan, 1973, has been sought against the Respondent No.1 [Justice Jahangiri] on the ground that as he has no legal certification, therefore, he is not eligible to hold his office. Hence, in view of the gravity and sensitivity of the issue at hand, Mr. Ashtar Ali Ausaf and Barrister Zafar Ullah Khan, Advocates Supreme Court of Pakistan are hereby appointed as amicus curiae."

The court issued notices to Attorney General Mansoor Usman Awan and Advocate General Islamabad Ayyaz Shaukat. The hearing was adjourned until October 21.

The courtroom was packed with members of the legal fraternity, including representatives of the Islamabad Bar Council, Islamabad High Court Bar Association, and District Bar Association of Islamabad. Pakistan Tehreek-i-Insaf (PTI) lawmaker Sher Afzal Khan Marwat was also present.

The petition relies on official

correspondence from the University of Karachi, which reportedly declared Justice Jahangiri's LLB degree "invalid". Key allegations include different roll numbers for Part-I and Part-II exams — AIL-5968/87 and AIL-7124/87 in his LLB programme.

The university confirmed it is "impossible" for a single student to be allotted two numbers in the same programme.

The first number (AIL-5968/87) was already allotted to another candidate, Imtiaz Ahmad.

The principal of Government Islamia Law College, Karachi, stated that no student by the name "Tariq Mehmood s/o Qazi Muhammad Akram" under enrollment number AIL-7124/87 was admitted in the relevant period.

The University's Controller of Examinations concluded in writing that the degree and mark sheets are "invalid".

The petitioner argued that the appointment of a judge without the requisite legal qualification is not a technical matter but a violation of citizens' fundamental rights, undermining the sanctity of the judiciary.

Shortly after the order, the IHC

Registrar's Office issued a revised duty roster, excluding Justice Jahangiri. His division and single benches were abolished.

Between September 17 and 19, the court will function with three division benches and six single benches.

Division benches comprising CJ Dogar and Justice Azam Khan will hear general cases; Justices Babar Sattar and Sardar Ijaz Ishaq Khan will hear tax matters and Justices Muhammad Asif and Inam Amin Minhas will take up general cases.

The decision sparked immediate outrage among the bar associations. At a press conference, Islamabad Bar Council Vice Chairman Raja Aleem Abbasi condemned the move as an assault on judicial independence, calling it "the darkest day in the history of the judiciary."

Abbasi argued that under Article 209 of the Constitution, only the Supreme Judicial Council has authority to inquire into the conduct of a judge. "Never in Pakistan's history has a judge been stopped from working by another judge," he said, adding that the ruling had been made under "external pressure" and

amounted to enforcing the "law of the jungle."

The bar council announced a complete strike and rally in the Islamabad High Court and District Courts on Wednesday, along with a general body meeting in G-11 to determine further action.

"You insult your judges, you insult the judiciary. Principles are clear — no judge can be removed except through Article 209. We will resist unconstitutional decisions," Abbasi declared.

It may be mentioned that Justice Jahangiri's legal career spanned over 30 years.

He held important portfolios like Deputy Prosecutor General of the National Accountability Bureau (NAB), Deputy Attorney General and Advocate General of Islamabad.

He was appointed as a judge of the Islamabad High Court on December 30, 2020.

He came into the limelight after he issued a blanket order for former prime minister Imran Khan following his arrest on May 9, 2023.

His degree issue surfaced last year, while he was hearing the election petitions of runners-up of all three constituencies of Islamabad.

SC explains security protocols for retired judges

Page 4

By Nasir Iqbal

ISLAMABAD: The Supreme Court has explained that though retired judges of the top court will remain entitled to lifetime security strictly in accordance with a presidential order, their widows are not covered.

In an announcement here on Tuesday, the Supreme Court clarified that a letter regarding provision of security to retired SC judges, which was addressed to the secretary interior, has revised its security protocols to the extent of widows of retired judges. The inclusion of the widows in the letter was inadvertent, the announcement clarified, adding that the reference to widows has accordingly been withdrawn since they were not covered under the Presidential Order No 7 of 2018.

However, the apex court reaffirmed that retired SC judges remain entitled to lifetime security strictly in accordance with the presidential order and the applicable rules and protocols.

This entitlement reflects the sensitive nature of their past office and the continuing security concerns that accompany it, the announcement explained.

On September 13, the court had announced that the SC, in a bid to streamline and rationalise the security of Chief Justice of Pakistan (CJP) Yahya Afridi, had scaled down the number of official vehicles from eight to two, resulting in the release of a considerable number of security personnel for routine policing duties.

The security regime for serving judges has also been regulated suitably, making it rational and aligned with the entitlements under the rules.

In the same spirit, the security for retired SC judges has also been regulated in accordance with applicable rules, established security protocols, and entitlements, including the relevant presidential order that provides lifetime security to retired judges, considering the sensitive nature of their past office and continuing security concerns.

In order to operationalise these security protocols, without conferring any extraordinary benefit, added concession or privilege, a circular has been issued to scale down deployment of force in excess of entitlement, reaffirming compliance with rules, and to facilitate coordination between the Supreme Court, the Ministry of Interior, and provincial authorities for implementation.

Leopard on the loose in Muzaffarabad captured after 36 hours

Page 4

By Tariq Naqash

MUZAFFARABAD: A leopard that had played “hide and seek” with residents of the AJK capital for more than 36 hours was finally captured on Tuesday afternoon, bringing much-needed relief to the panicked populace.

The drama began late Sunday night, when reports emerged on social media that a leopard had been spotted in the Sathra area. Residents fanned out with torches and mobile phone lights to trace it, but in vain.

CCTV footage that surfaced later showed the animal roaming through Madina Market, a busy commercial hub about a kilometre away, without coming into contact with night watchmen or passers-by.

On Monday morning, the big cat was sighted in the Central Plate neighbourhood near Jinnah Dental Hospital, where it leapt past a female resident and crouched in an open plot beside her house. “Surprisingly, it was not violent but friendly,” she recalled.

Another resident, Raja Asad Khan, described his unnerving face-to-face encounter when the leopard jumped into his house. “As I stepped out of the washroom, I suddenly found myself staring at it. I swiftly locked the room, retreated to safety and alerted emergency services,” he said, adding that the animal appeared overwhelmed rather than aggressive. “It did not deliberately target my house. It was simply fleeing human pursuit.”

Police and wildlife teams rushed to the

spot, but the leopard slipped away again, sparking conflicting reports about its whereabouts and a flood of memes on social media.

Later in the day, the animal entered a scrap warehouse along Plate Road owned by Matiullah Khan, an Afghan national settled in Muzaffarabad. His children managed to lock it in a room, but the leopard forced its way out through a narrow opening and climbed onto the roof before disappearing into a three-foot-wide alley, hemmed in by tall buildings, leading to a basement where it eventually got stuck.

Wildlife teams attempted to tranquilize it with a dart gun, but the confined space made it nearly impossible to strike properly. By Tuesday morning, the leopard had become visibly stressed and vets advised against seda-

tion, fearing it could prove fatal. At this stage, Mr Khan volunteered to take matters into his own hands. Donning a helmet and gloves provided by the wildlife department, he crawled into the cavity with ropes as cameras rolled.

“It attacked me thrice, but I didn’t give up. I wanted to rid this city, which gave me livelihood and respect, of fear and panic,” he later told *Dawn*.

With assistance from wildlife watchers Junaid Akram and Raja Mudassar and local volunteer Hasnain Ali Khokhar, the leopard was finally subdued and dragged into the open, before being shifted to an iron cage.

The animal, believed to be aged between 1.5 and 2.5 years, was later transported to the wildlife department’s rehabilitation centre in Chela neighbourhood.

Power to slap super tax

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IHC comprising then Chief Justice Aamer Farooq and Justice Tariq Mehmood Jahangiri while hearing intra-court appeals had directed one of the respondents to continue paying tax liability under Section 4C as amended by the Finance Act, 2023.

The super tax, introduced by the PML-N government in 2015, applies to wealthy individuals, associations of persons and companies earning above Rs500 million. It levies 4 per cent tax on the income of banking companies and 3pc on other sectors to fund rehabilitation of temporarily displaced persons.

Mr Khokhar defended the constitutionality of Sections 4B and 4C of the ITO, 2001, stressing that under Article 77, parliament has exclusive authority to levy taxes. He argued that the super tax, introduced through Finance Acts 2015 and 2022, was a lawful exercise of fiscal power.

He noted that Section 4B, which initially imposed super tax on high-income taxpayers, had already been upheld by all high courts. Issues such as double taxation, violation of Article 25 and legislative competence had been decided in favour of the federation.

Turning to Section 4C, introduced in 2022, which extended the levy through progressive slabs and sector-specific categories, Mr Khokhar said the high courts erred by reconstructing the statutory scheme. This amounted to judicial legislation, he argued.

Under Article 199, he emphasized, courts may only strike down laws that clearly violate fundamental rights, not redesign tax schemes. By doing otherwise, the high courts committed judicial overreach and upset the balance of power between legislature and judiciary, he said.

On the claim that super tax constituted double taxation, he called the argument “wholly misconceived,” noting that under Article 77 and Entry 47 of the federal legislative List, parliament has plenary authority to levy taxes on income other than agricultural income.

Section 2(63) of the Ordinance defines “tax” to include super tax, while Section 3 provides that income tax shall be charged for each tax year where expressly provided. Thus, super tax is not a separate levy but an additional component of income tax on high-income earners, comparable to a surcharge or advance tax, he explained.

Engage with Taliban

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their leadership into Pakistan and alleged that the latter was now becoming a 'safe haven' for the militant group.

Imran echoes dialogue call

Khalilzad's remarks found echo in the views of the incarcerated former PM, who has also called for dialogue to address the militancy currently plaguing the province of Khyber Pakhtunkhwa — where his party is in power. In a tweet posted to his X account on Tuesday, Mr Khan said that operations initiated in the former tribal areas were leading to rising police, military and civilian casualties.

"This approach can never establish peace. Lasting peace only comes through dialogue," he said. He alleged that what was being attempted in KP was merely an attempt to discredit the PTI government, and claimed a military operation would only fuel further terrorism.

As police are diverted to counter the rising threat from terrorism, governance and law and order will collapse, he said. He urged all KP lawmakers to sit with the chief minister to urgently resolve the challenges of the province, and called on his allies — namely Tehreek-i-Tahaffuz Ayeen-i-Pakistan leader Mahmood Khan Achakzai — to send a peace delegation to Afghanistan.

PTA chairman's appointment declared unlawful

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that the post of member (administration) shall be deemed not to exist. It further directed that retired Maj-Gen Hafeezur Rehman immediately cease to hold the positions of member (administration) and chairman of the PTA.

According to the order, the senior-most serving member of the PTA shall assume charge as acting chairman until a regular appointment is made.

The court also instructed the government to amend the PTA Appointment Rules to clearly specify the qualifications, criteria and process for appointing a chairman, in line with established precedents. The judgement emphasised that public appointments must comply with principles of transparency, fairness and legality, warning that "any edifice built on an illegal foundation must crumble."

A copy of the judgement has been forwarded to the cabinet division and to PTA members for immediate compliance.

The case had been pending before Justice Sattar since 2023, with the judgement reserved on Aug 20, just four days after the IHC administration notified a special division bench of Justice Sattar and Justice Sardar Ejaz Ishaq Khan to hear tax references exclusively.

According to the notification, both judges were confined to the division bench and could not preside over single-bench hearings. Since the notification became effective on Sept 1, Justice Sattar concluded the hearing on Aug 20 and announced the judgement on Sept 16. However, no formal cause list had been issued before the pronouncement.

Appeal by PTA chairman

Subsequently, the decision was challenged through an intra-court appeal. The appellant, the chairman of PTA, stated that he had first been appointed as member (administration) on 24 May 2023 and was elevated to the position of chairman the very next day.

The appeal emphasised that retired Maj Gen Rehman has been discharging his duties in accordance with the applicable rules and regulations. It further asserts that the appeal has been filed to legally justify both his appointment and his tenure as chairman.

The appellant has also requested that the court fix the matter for urgent hearing, contending that the removal order has created administrative uncertainty within the authority and disrupted its functioning.

An IHC division bench is expected to hear the petition within the next couple of days.

'Nuclear arsenal keeps Indian designs in check'

By Our Staff Reporter

ISLAMABAD: A top adviser to the country's nuclear command and control body believes that Pakistan's nuclear arsenal is what is keeping Indian military designs in check.

Speaking at an event organised by the Islamabad Policy Research Institute (IPRI) on Tuesday, retired Lt Gen Khalid Ahmed Kidwai said that the country's Full Spectrum Deterrence (FSD) — or minimum credible deterrence — was never compromised during the May standoff with India.

Lt Gen Kidwai, an adviser to the country's National Command Authority (NCA), also noted that the newly-formed Army Rocket Force Command (ARFC) will raise the nuclear threshold by providing an additional layer of strategic deterrence between conventional operations and the potential employment of nuclear forces.

He explained that the ARFC has merely a response to modern battlefield needs, while the nuclear deterrent remains in place as the ultimate shield against India.

A former head of the army's Strategic Plans Division (SPD), Gen. Kidwai said that Pakistan's FSD worked in both directions, east and west, and it was no 'bluff', according to a press release issued after the event.

He stressed that, unlike India, Pakistan has repeatedly demonstrated that restraint and responsibility are the key components of its nuclear policy.

"The large size of the Indian army does not tell the entire story... quality, technology, and training are the force multipliers that determine the victor in an armed confrontation," he remarked.

"India not only failed to achieve any of its politico-strategic-military objectives, but it also suffered major military reverses, especially in the IAF," he pointed out.

Robbers take Rs220m in Kech heist

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Three killed in Nasirabad

By Behram Baloch and Ali Jan Mangi

G W A D A R / D E R A MURAD JAMALI: Armed men looted Rs220 million from the van of a private security company at gunpoint on the M-8 motorway in Kech district, while two separate shootings in Nasirabad district claimed three lives on Tuesday.

Police said the security company was transporting Rs220m from two private

banks in Turbat to Karachi. The robbers intercepted the van at the Dasht-Kuddan crossing, around 150kms from Turbat, held the security guards hostage and fled with the cash, which included Rs145 million belonging to one bank and over Rs71 million to another.

"Around Rs220 million was looted from the security company van," a senior police officer confirmed to *Dawn*, adding that security forces had cordoned off the area and launched a search operation to track down the culprits.

Meanwhile, in Nasirabad district, three people were killed in two

separate shootings on Tuesday. Police said armed men shot dead two brothers in the Chatter area as they were returning home. The victims, identified as Muhammad Hashim and Ahmed, died on the spot after sustaining multiple bullet wounds.

Police attributed the killings to a land dispute. The bodies were shifted to the district hospital in Dera Murad Jamali for medico-legal formalities before being handed over to the family.

In Chatter tehsil, a man identified as Juro Khan was shot dead by gunmen while he was passing through the Phulaji area.

Punjab's wheat restrictions trigger domino effect

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prices have skyrocketed in provinces like KP, where a 20kg bag of flour is now selling for up to Rs2,800, compared to around Rs1,800 in Punjab. This has placed an unbearable burden on low-income families already struggling with inflation.

KP Governor Faisal Karim Kundi publicly condemned the ban, calling it a "blatant violation of Article 151" and a "serious breach of national unity". The KP Assembly has also adopted a unanimous resolution denouncing Punjab's restrictions on wheat supply, citing a 68 per cent hike in flour prices in the province.

It is not a new phenomenon but a recurring issue that resurfaces whenever there is a shortage of wheat, often caused by natural disasters such as floods or by low production due to inadequate or poor-quality farm inputs, particularly urea and DAP fertilisers. The country witnessed the same issue in 2020, 2022 and 2023.

The problem deepened when Punjab, which traditionally procured and stocked more than four million tonnes each har-

vest to stabilise prices and ensure year-round availability of grain, withdrew from this role under international agreements.

Govt stance vs market realities

Punjab officials maintained that the restrictions are a necessary measure to ensure food security within the province and to combat hoarding and smuggling.

They argued that preventing wheat from being diverted to feed mills or sold to other provinces at inflated prices is essential for ensuring a stable supply for local consumers.

They also pointed to the National Finance Commission award, under which each province is responsible for its own food security and should not blame other federating units for shortages.

However, millers and market analysts argued that this policy is counterproductive. They contended that the ban creates an artificial shortage, leading to market instability and driving up prices nationwide.

The Pakistan Institute of Development Economics (PIDE) has

consistently advocated for a deregulated wheat market, arguing that bans on interprovincial movement only create inefficiency and corruption.

Majid Abdullah, president of the Progressive Flour Millers Group, warned that if administrative measures to regulate the so-called deregulated market continue, the private sector will be reluctant to invest in the wheat sector next season.

This could force the government to import grain at much higher rates than what is available locally. Abdullah highlighted the irony of the situation, noting that Punjab authorities had previously encouraged private investment, even offering bank loans for the purpose of purchasing large quantities of grain during harvest season.

He added that without proper legal protection, the deregulation process remains uncertain and vulnerable to being reversed by a future government, which could make private investment in storage facilities worthless.

"Stability of the market needs a consistent, thorough policy protected by a proper piece of legislation," Mr

Abdullah stated.

Farmers' woes

The ban also has a ripple effect on farmers. While the government aims to secure a stable price for consumers, its actions are seen as a disincentive for farmers.

They may choose to plant other crops in the upcoming sowing season if they cannot get a fair price for their wheat, which could lead to a significant decline in domestic production and force the country to rely on costly imports.

Mr Abdullah cautioned that administrative efforts to control prices, especially with the next sowing season approaching, will discourage farmers who are already hesitant to plant wheat after failing to get good prices for their produce in the last two seasons.

The situation underscores a deep-seated tension between the government's desire to control prices for the public and the free-market principles essential for a healthy agricultural economy.

The federal government, under pressure from affected provinces, is now being urged to intervene and restore the free movement of wheat to avert a full-blown food crisis.

Not enough

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WHILE the tone of the participants of the Arab-Islamic Summit in Doha on Monday was certainly hard towards Israel, unless there are tangible actions to back up the meeting's proposals, the Arab and Muslim world's reaction will remain limited to rhetoric. The conclave was convened after Israel's reckless attack last week on the Qatari capital, in which it targeted Hamas members as well as a local security man. While Israel has been hitting Muslim states relentlessly since Oct 7, 2023 — mainly Iran and its regional allies — this time the target was different: a pro-US monarchy that also maintains ties with Hamas. Perhaps the newest choice of target explains why the Islamic world's monarchs and rulers rushed to Doha to deliberate. Yet few actionable goals emerged from the summit.

For instance, states were urged to review their economic and diplomatic relations with the Zionist state. One would have thought a definite line of action would have emerged in this regard, not wishy-washy suggestions. Meanwhile, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif proposed the formation of a "task force" to deter Israeli aggression, while Foreign Minister Ishaq Dar told Al Jazeera that Pakistan could contribute to efforts if a combined Muslim security force was considered. And yet, as the Muslim world deliberates, Israel continues the bloodbath in Gaza. On Tuesday, Tel Aviv launched the ground invasion of Gaza City. Meanwhile, the UN's Independent International Commission of Inquiry on the Occupied Palestinian Territory has said Israel is indeed committing genocide in Gaza. This is the latest in a series of expert opinions, which have reaffirmed the fact that the Zionist state is carrying out a modern holocaust in the Strip.

The Palestinian people have suffered long enough, while there is a very real threat of Israel attacking even more Muslim states as part of its strategy to dominate the region through the sword. Therefore, much more was expected from the Arab League/OIC moot. For one, the complete diplomatic and economic boycott of Israel — and those states that help fund and support its genocide — until it ceases the violence should have been a unified decision, not an option. Words devoid of actions reflect division and weakness within the Muslim world. Additionally, the GCC's expectation that the US will use its "influence on Israel in order for it to stop this behaviour" is divorced from reality. The Trump administration is openly pro-Zionist, featuring members who consider it a religious and ideological duty to defend Israel and all its crimes. Therefore, if the Arab/Muslim bloc is serious about ending the holocaust in Gaza, and preventing more members of its fraternity from becoming Israeli targets, they will need to depend on themselves, and come up with a solid plan to end Israeli impunity.

Unchanged rate

THE State Bank's decision to keep its key policy rate unchanged at 11pc, for the third time in a row, signals its concerns over the evolving risks to the inflation and growth outlook as the country continues to reel under the impact of the floods. This is despite the SBP's confidence in the ability of the economy to weather the flood-related destruction in Punjab — our largest agricultural producer — and beyond. The decision is shaped mainly by a need to balance the near-term potential rise in food inflation — as indicated by the surging weekly price indicators — and import demand amid what the bank calls a slight deterioration in the macroeconomic outlook, while also focusing on the medium-term need to stabilise expectations and preserve hard-won stability. With floods threatening Kharif crop yields, food prices and the current account balance, the immediate outlook is clouded. Therefore, the bank believes that inflation may breach the 5-7pc target for much of the present year, while growth may ease to the lower band of its previous forecast of 3.25-4.25pc range.

Yet the bank feels that these shocks, while significant, will not overwhelm the national economy, which stands on a "stronger footing to withstand the negative fallout of the ongoing floods as compared to previous major flood events". Its confidence stems from a number of positive developments. Headline consumer inflation has significantly moderated and core inflation is trending down — albeit slowly. Official international reserves have surged to \$14.3bn, despite debt repayments and the current account deficit, and are expected to reach \$15.5bn by the end of 2025. Besides, remittances remain robust. On the fiscal side, the growth in FBR tax collection, which fell slightly short of the target during July-August, is expected to lead to a significant primary surplus in Q1-FY26 with the help of SBP profits. Moreover, global trade uncertainty has reduced following the announcement of revised US import tariffs, while commodity price outlook remains benign. Nonetheless, the bigger challenge lies ahead if fiscal pressures mount due to reconstruction spending and potential slowdown in revenues. In this situation, the SBP is right to emphasise the continuation of reforms — preferably related to tax and state-owned enterprises — and a prudent monetary and fiscal policy mix to create space for additional development spending and strengthen external and fiscal buffers to cushion the impact of future economic shocks.

Rain-borne risks

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HEAVERY rains have left Pakistan awash not just with floodwater but also disease. Across Punjab and Sindh, hospitals are overrun with patients suffering from mosquito-borne illnesses and waterborne infections. Entire neighbourhoods have turned into stagnant ponds, ideal breeding grounds for *Aedes aegypti*. The result is a surge in dengue cases, with malaria close behind. Dirty water is also taking its toll. Reports from relief camps describe children doubled over with diarrhoea, families struggling with gastric pain and vomiting, and doctors battling suspected cholera clusters. In makeshift shelters, skin rashes, eye infections and coughs are spreading fast. These maladies are hardly new. They return each monsoon, exposing the same underlying weakness: Pakistan's creaking sanitation and drainage systems, and its chronic underinvestment in public health. The Met Office has issued a high-risk dengue alert from Sept 20 through early December, citing waterlogging, humidity above 60pc, and continuing rainfall as near-perfect conditions for the mosquito's spread. Forecasts also point to further rainfall, raising fears of fresh flooding and prolonging the public health crisis.

Yet the response remains reactive. Provincial authorities issue warnings; local councils scramble to fog neighbourhoods against mosquitoes; hospitals plead for more medicines. International agencies deliver purification tablets and rehydration salts. But little is done to prepare before the rains fall. The result is an annual cycle of avoidable suffering, disproportionately borne by the poor who lack access to clean water or private healthcare. Breaking this cycle requires more than temporary relief. The government must invest in drainage and sewerage systems in its cities, where unplanned sprawl has outpaced infrastructure. Disease-surveillance networks must be strengthened so outbreaks can be tracked and contained swiftly. Relief camps need reliable supplies of safe drinking water and sanitation facilities. And vector control should be year-round, not merely after floodwaters rise. Unless preparedness replaces firefighting, each monsoon will continue to unleash misery.

Bonding with chatbots



IT starts casually; a person starts talking to a chatbot because it's easily accessible, it doesn't have any time limitations, it has no emotional bandwidth to take into account, and gives an instant, human-like reaction to any deep or superficial thought. But it's all artificial, as the 'A' in AI signifies.

Yet, more and more people, especially in younger demographics, are using this new technology for emotional and mental support. A 2025 global study by Kantar published in July showed that 54 per cent of consumers had used AI for at least one emotional or mental well-being purpose. Data otherwise on this matter is scarce.

There are multiple reasons why people are turning to chatbots: therapy, in this part of the world especially, remains a novel, sometimes taboo concept, not to mention expensive; terms like 'trauma dumping' have created distances in personal relationships, especially among young adults, where you take into account the other person's needs before sharing your own; there's no fear of judgement, reprimand, or even opinion; and then of course, ease of accessibility and familiarity as the technology is encouraged among professionals and even students.

But there's no manual on how to do it correctly, and so the relationship or bond a person may form with these bots — trained to sound like caring humans who offer validating and tailored responses — depends on each individual's personality and state of mind.

In the cases of 29-year-old Sophie Rottenberg and 16-year-old Adam Raine in the US, the attachments formed with the chatbots contributed to the loss of their lives. I say contributed because while it has not been established that they caused them to end their life, the AI companions couldn't stop them either after being wholly aware of their intentions. In Rottenberg's case, as detailed by her mother in an article in *The New York Times*, she had been confiding in a ChatGPT AI therapist called Harry. The chat logs revealed that while Harry did ask her to seek professional help or reach out to someone, it also validated her dark thoughts.

Raine's parents, who have filed a lawsuit against OpenAI, said he started using ChatGPT as a resource to help with schoolwork, then to explore his interests, and eventually as his confidante about anxiety and mental distress. In a statement following the lawsuit, OpenAI acknowl-

edged the shortcomings of its models when it comes to mental and emotional distress.

Here's an example from OpenAI's statement that may help illustrate what this article is trying to address: "Someone might enthusiastically tell the model they believe they can drive 24/7 because they realised they're invincible after not sleeping for two nights. Today, ChatGPT may not recognise this as dangerous or infer play and — by curiously exploring — could subtly reinforce it."

Here's what to note: at this point, bots cannot identify different types of distress and they can easily, without detection, encourage someone to explore a dangerous idea further, invariably validating it. And these limitations go beyond ChatGPT to other chatbots commercially availa-

Bots cannot identify different types of distress and can easily encourage someone to explore a dangerous idea.

ble in the market at the moment.

A psychiatrist in Boston earlier this year spent several hours exchanging messages with 10 different chatbots, including Character.AI, Nomi and Replika, pretending to be teenagers struggling with various crises. Dr Andrew Clark found some of them to be 'excellent' and some 'just creepy and potentially dangerous'.

"And it's really hard to tell upfront: It's like a field of mushrooms, some of which are going to be poisonous and some nutritious." Therein lies the rub: using AI freely without any guardrails, personally or professionally (as this writer has previously pointed to as well), when we're still not fully aware of its harms.

Some companies and developers are currently testing bots for mental health concerns and developing ones solely as therapists. Dartmouth researchers in March conducted the first-ever clinical trial of a generative AI-powered therapy chatbot, called Therabot, and found that the software resulted in significant improvements in participants' symptoms. However, a Stanford study

showed that AI therapy chatbots may not only lack effectiveness compared to human therapists but could also contribute to harmful stigma and dangerous responses. Clearly, much work has to be done in this area.

When I say AI is artificial, I'm not discrediting the usefulness or resourcefulness of the chatbots; it's a fact that these AI interfaces are trained on data sets, without a nuanced understanding of different cultures and family set-ups, and can model human behaviour, offering the appearance of a genuine bond while freeing users from feeling burdened or burdensome for others. As Pakistan also embraces this technology, we should keep in mind there are many vulnerable individuals who would want to seek out such 'help'.

According to WHO estimates, 24 million people in Pakistan are in need of psychiatric assistance and the country has only 0.19 psychiatrists per 100,000 inhabitants. There is only a handful of literature to help us gauge levels of anxiety and stress amongst youngsters; even the research available doesn't fully reflect the state of a nation with a youth majority, grappling with questions of identity, employment and career struggles, academic pressures, societal silence on topics like postpartum depression and marital relations, security concerns and other pressing issues. The cases of Sophie Rottenberg and Adam Raine, just two among others that have come to light, may have taken place across continents but should serve as a reminder of the downside of overreliance on AI. The role of a parent, partner, friend or any other close relation is pivotal for those struggling with anxiety or depression, while the alienation that a chatbot, mistaken for an ally, can create with these relationships cannot be overlooked.

As generative AI becomes more acceptable for personal, professional and academic use, we must identify and create awareness about its blind spots. The onus is on the company telling its employee to become more familiar with AI or the parent saying it's okay to use it for a presentation to determine which apps are appropriate and safe for which users. The use of the internet itself, including social media, holds perils too but the human-mirroring ability of AI makes it a much more complex technology to allow a free-for-all approach. ■

The writer is a journalist and project lead of iVerify Pakistan.



A summit of inaction

Muslim states have watched the worst genocide in recent times in silence.

THE much-touted emergency summit in Doha of leaders of Arab-Islamic countries ended with a whimper. The joint statement is strong on rhetoric but weak on concrete action. The head of states of nearly 60 countries had gathered in Doha to produce a decisive response to Israel after its attack on Qatar last week. But it was all tough talk — nothing more. There is no real strategy to deal with Israel's increasing bellicosity or to defuse regional tensions.

The attack on Qatar was yet another act of brazen aggression against a sovereign Arab country by Israel. The Zionist state was seen to cross the line yet again when it struck one of America's closest allies in the Gulf, which is also home to the largest US military base in the region. Anger was palpable across the Arab world and international condemnation of the attack raised expectations that strong measures would be taken to stop Israel's growing aggression.

Qatar was the sixth country attacked this year by Israel, which is continuing with its genocidal war in Gaza. Israel has killed over 65,000 people so far — most of them women and children. More than a million people have been displaced. With limited food supplies and no cessation in Israeli hostilities, the entire population of the occupied enclave is in danger. Scores of children are dying daily of hunger.

Meanwhile, the Islamic bloc has watched the worst genocide in recent history in silence. Some Arab countries have even continued with their diplomatic and trade relations with Israel. True, there were some voices of protest but no more. Then Israel attacked Lebanon, occupied more territory inside Syria and bombed Yemen and Iran. The attack on Iran's nuclear facilities in June was the most brazen joint military action by Israel and the US against a sovereign state. Yet, apart from some meek condemnation, no concrete action was taken by the Muslim world.

The Zionist state extended its military operations to the West Bank and announced plans to expand the settlement forcibly taking

Palestinian land. Now Israel's extreme right government has announced that it intends to permanently occupy Gaza and force its entire population to leave. It is apparent that Israel's genocide in Gaza and attack on Arab countries has full US backing.

Israel has received billions of dollars in military aid from the US and enjoys Washington's full support in its military incursions in the region. Not only that, Arab countries have failed to put any kind of pressure on Washington to use its leverage to stop Israel, and, in fact, made every effort to please President Donald Trump when he visited the Middle East in the summer. The gulf sheikhdoms promised to invest trillions of dollars in the US. Qatar gifted a \$400 million plane to Trump, besides signing a multibillion-dollar deal with the US for the purchase of arms. But even that proved no guarantee of safety from the attacks of America's closest ally.

Israel's fighter planes struck a residential building in a Doha neighbourhood last week, killing five Hamas members and a Qatari security officer. The attack targeted the Hamas negotiating team, which had gathered to discuss a fresh peace plan proposed by the Trump administration. A top Hamas leader was also present. They had reportedly agreed to most of the proposals when Israel struck — missing the five negotiating members but killing some other members.

It was obvious that the purpose of the Israeli attack was to sabotage any ceasefire deal. Qatar has been involved in efforts to mediate between Israel and Hamas since the invasion of Gaza almost two years ago. Doha also hosted Israeli officials engaged in the negotiations that had American backing. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu justified the attack, indicating he didn't need Washington's approval. Trump said that he was not informed about the attack by Israel and got to know about the impending strike from US military sources.

And yet, Qatar was not alerted — quite intrigu-

ing if we consider that thousands of American soldiers are based in that country. Moreover, Qatar's air defence system is supported by US technology. Trump expressed his displeasure over the strike but never condemned Israel by name. Critics believe that the overdependence of Qatar and other Gulf sheikhdoms on the US makes these states extremely vulnerable to Israeli aggression.

A statement released after the summit warned that Israel's "brutal" aggression "threatens all that has been achieved on the path towards establishing normal relations with Israel, including existing and future agreements". It also called upon the US to use its leverage to stop Israel. The suggestion makes little sense given that the Zionist state's strong lobby has far greater leverage over American administrations.

While the Arab and other Muslim heads of states were deliberating on united action against Israel, Netanyahu appeared to indicate, at a joint press conference with US Secretary of State Marco Rubio, that he would attack Qatar again to eliminate Hamas leaders. The two seemed united notwithstanding reports about differences between Trump and Netanyahu. Top US diplomats cast doubt on the chances of a negotiated peace deal that could end the Gaza war.

For sure, Arab countries have some leverage they could use to pressure Israel, but there is no real sense of unity among them on concrete action. The interests of these countries vary, making it difficult for them to agree on an effective strategy to deal with the growing Israeli threat. Some Arab countries are not even ready to break off diplomatic ties with Israel for economic or security reasons. A divided house cannot protect itself. Statements of solidarity are often just for show and mean nothing. ■

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Difficult scenario

CROSS-border terrorism (CBT) refers to terrorists crossing national boundaries to carry out attacks or using foreign territory for training, planning and launching operations. These activities are inter-linked with illicit networks that finance terrorism, creating a broader 'illegal spectrum of crime'. CBT between Pakistan and Afghanistan has been a complex issue. Historical grievances, regional instability, arrival and departure of superpowers, weak governance in Afghanistan and the presence of militant groups in border areas have complicated the scenario.

During the USSR's military presence in Afghanistan, fighters resisting the Soviets were accorded the status of 'mujahideen'; subsidiaries of those groups continue to operate. Militant outfits challenging peace in Pakistan were proscribed; to date, Pakistan has banned 82 organisations, many with roots across the border.

The proximity of tribal districts to Afghan provinces has heightened security challenges and harmed the peace index. Decades-long weak governance in the former Fata, hostile entities and ideological recruitment have hampered counterterrorism (CT) efforts. Despite financial constraints, Pakistan has fenced most of its border but faces persistent violations.

Withdrawal of US troops and the Afghan Taliban's return to power in 2021 raised hopes of reduced militancy, but in fact, the opposite occurred. CBT remains rooted in historical, geopolitical and security dynamics. The trust deficit, violent non-state actors and weak Afghan border control make the task difficult. Before the merger of Fata into KP, law enforcement was based on tribal customs and maintained by Levies and Khasadars. After the merger, KP Police was tasked with transforming these forces into a professional service, altering the dynamics of countering CBT. Weapons left behind after the US withdrawal are now used by militants against LEAs, as seen in the Jaffar Express attack.

Illicit financing sustains extremism. Across the border, the opium trade, arms smuggling, informal transactions, and extortion generate funds, while cyberspace provides propaganda, recruitment and fundraising opportunities. Pakistan's proximity to Afghanistan — one of the largest narco-producing countries — and Iran — a gateway to Europe — increases its vulnerability. To address these complexities and curb illegal spectrum activities, measures have been included in the National Action Plan.

Countering CBT can't be separated from dismantling the illegal networks sustaining it. A security-based response will not suffice. A multipronged strategy is

required: governance reform, regional cooperation, socioeconomic resilience and technological advancement. The situation demands tackling not only the symptoms but also the structural enablers. Improved intelligence cooperation, denial of space to militants by Afghanistan, stronger CT efforts by both sides, and international support for dialogue and development can help reduce CBT.

According to the 35th UN sanctions monitoring team report (2025), the number of militants on Afghan soil remained unchanged, with a surge in cross-border attacks. Measures such as fencing, drone surveillance, regional diplomacy, financial intelligence, anti-money laundering measures, judicial reforms, youth empowerment and rehabilitation of former militants all need greater investment.

Administrative reforms have also played a role. Before the 25th Constitutional Amendment, the then Fata was administered federally. Now, through constitutional and administrative measures,

Response based on security will not suffice.

provincial governance has been extended. Merger of the former tribal areas and the division of Chitral and South Waziristan into two districts each are steps to improve governance. Twelve joint check-posts have been established in KP to

enhance collaboration between the federal and provincial LEAs. Profiling non-customs paid vehicles and linking data with CNICs and biometric systems will help track suspicious activity.

Globally, best practices include agreements, intelligence-sharing, joint operations and extraditions. Integrated border management, surveillance through drones and biometrics, CCTV networks and motion sensors are widely used. Prevention of radicalisation through community engagement, education and local partnerships has proved effective. To effectively counter CBT, there is no single perfect solution, but rather a combination of technology, policy, cooperation and diplomacy, including fencing, intelligence-sharing, and global and regional institutional cooperation.

Border security is a shared responsibility. Instability on one side inevitably affects the other. Only enhanced bilateral engagement and intelligence cooperation can help maintain peace. ■

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Brazil's unusual 9/11

IT has been a tumultuous week on the global stage, with tales of the unexpected ranging from a youthful uprising, massacre and swift regime change in Nepal to the death by shooting of a prominent young far-right activist in Utah.

Charlie Kirk's murder was weaponised by America's ruling elite as a bludgeon against what it sees as the 'radical left', and the irony of targeting his posthumous critics, both domestic and foreign, is apparently lost even on those who elevate his (frankly hypocritical) commitment to free speech above his smorgasbord of obnoxious views on race, gender, immigration, gun violence, etc.

Any expectation, though, that the orchestrated national mourning would drown out the clamour over Donald Trump's close relationship with Jeffrey Epstein was dented by the dismissal of Britain's ambassador to Washington on similar grounds. Unlike Trump, Peter Mandelson — an oleaginous, smarmy and allegedly corrupt survivor from the Blair administration — remained on close terms with Epstein even after the latter's conviction over organised paedophilia. The increasingly unpopular Keir Starmer's determination to stand by Mandelson until a few days ago has added to the British prime minister's self-inflicted woes by raising fresh questions about his judgement among both friends and foes on the eve of Trump's arrival in London for a second state visit.

Meanwhile, continents away from the prospect of a new beginning for Nepal, another silver lining appeared in the skies above Brazil as former president Jair Bolsonaro was sentenced to 27 years in prison for attempting to orchestrate a coup he hoped would extend his disastrous rule after he lost the 2022 election to Luiz Inácio Lula da Silva.

The decisive judicial blow came on Sept 11 — for many Latin Americans a day associated more with the 1973 military coup in Chile than the toppling of the twin towers in 2001. Four out of five supreme court judges found Bolsonaro and his co-conspirators guilty of seeking to pervert the course of democracy by assassinating Lula, his (conservative) vice president-elect, and Justice Alexandre de Moraes. The plan to effectively reconstitute the wretched military regime that governed Brazil for 21 years from 1964 floundered chiefly because the army and air force chiefs were unwilling to play ball in 2022. The then naval chief has been sentenced alongside Bolsonaro.

The backdrop to this scenario has been Trump's efforts to intimidate South America's largest country into jettisoning its legal proprieties by permitting Bolsonaro

— hailed (or, more convincingly, derided) as a 'tropical Trump' after winning the 2018 election — to go scot-free.

That timeline incidentally coincides with Imran Khan's military-backed elevation to the top post, although his downfall and imprisonment were expedited, perhaps because the concept of due process carries more weight in Brazil than in Pakistan. The expensive efforts of Khan's American fan club to nudge the incoming Trump administration towards insisting on his release failed to pay off, while the Bolsonaro lobby proved more efficacious, with Trump and his acolytes regularly decrying the 'witch hunt' in Brazil and imposing 50pc tariffs, despite America's substantial trade surplus, alongside sanctions against the likes of Moraes.

"It's very much like what they tried to do with me, but they didn't get away with it," was Trump's response to the sentencing of his soulmate. A couple of months ago, Lula was quoted as saying, "I've said to President Trump if what happened in

'Tropical Trump' got his comeuppance.

the Capitol had happened in Brazil, he would be put on trial here." He was referring to the Jan 6, 2021, attempt by Trump supporters to overturn the

result of the 2020 presidential election, which is what Bolsonaro backers sought to emulate on Jan 8, 2023.

The Jan 6 culprits were amnestied after Trump returned to power, and are now demanding compensation. In contrast, the masterminds behind Jan 8, who copied the US example after failing to arrange a military coup, are in the dock. It remains to be seen whether Bolsonaro, under house arrest, will serve time in prison. Last week's verdict is bound to be appealed, and if that fails, there's the prospect of a congressional amnesty. The former para-trooper's belated comeuppance sparked jubilations across Brazil, but the country remains divided, and Bolsonaro's delusional fans still number in the millions.

Whatever happens in the next couple of months, next year's presidential election — in which Bolsonaro cannot legally compete, and Lula, ailing and on the cusp of turning 80, may decide not to — will be a test case for Brazil. Neither has designated an heir so far. One can only hope that Lula's model of a broad, barely ideological democracy, however flawed, will again trump the potentially rabid far-right alternative. ■

Anti-Indian feeling

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MANAMA (Bahrain). Nearly 150 prominent businessmen of Indian origin have been urged to leave Bahrain after alleged violation of currency control laws, and anti-Indian feeling is being felt in the Persian Gulf area. Several thousand Indians live along the Persian Gulf, and "telephone death threats have been reported against Indian embassy personnel in Dubai... ." In Bahrain, Indian Ambassador Prit Malik said ... he had issued special travel documents to about a dozen Indians, to enable them to leave the country, after their passports had been confiscated. But he denied any death threats had been received... . Indian businessmen have been installed in the Persian Gulf area for about 30 years, and are reportedly worried about developments which could force them to leave. — News agencies

[Meanwhile, as reported by news agencies from the UN,] the General Assembly today [Sept 16] ratified the recommendations of the Ad Hoc Committee of the seventh special session aimed at giving the developing countries a bigger share of the world's wealth. The Committee met ... after the Group of 77 finalised its proposals, and recommended ... detailed measures running into 20 pages.

No-war proposal

Page 7

KARACHI: New Delhi's belated response to ... Prime Minister ... Liaquat Ali Khan[']s concrete proposal of February last for a joint "no-war" declaration is believed to be disappointing, according to well-informed sources in the Pakistan capital. Pandit Nehru's reply — which has taken over six months — is understood to have reiterated more or less ... the Bharati Government's original stand of December last mooted a brief platitudinous declaration renouncing war and merely stating in general terms the resolve of the two countries to settle all existing and future differences by recognised peaceful methods.

The Pakistan Prime Minister's proposal on the other hand, is stated to have been based on the universally accepted dictum that verbal professions — howsoever unambiguous — cannot remove causes of friction unless tangible action is simultaneously guaranteed.

As such the Karachi proposal envisaged the inclusion of a precise clear-cut procedure with an agreed time-table for resolving existing and future disputes and effectively eliminating causes of Pakistan-Bharat discord as an integral part of the suggested no-war declaration. — News agencies

Utility charges

Page 7

THE latest monthly bill I have received from the Pakistan Telecommunication Company Limited (PTCL) is showing an increase of Rs350. This is not a one-off incident.

Over the last year, PTCL has repeatedly increased the monthly charges for its broadband services by small but frequent increments of Rs200-300. Not much different is the case with the Water and Sanitation Agency (Wasa) and Sui Northern Gas Pipelines Limited (SNGPL).

While each increase might appear minor in isolation, the collective result is a significant annual burden, amounting to thousands of rupees. This practice is unethical as it lacks transparency.

Besides, customers are often not given proper justification, prior notice, or an option to opt out, making it feel more like an exploitative strategy than a fair adjustment.

Utility service-providers must be held accountable for unfair billing practices. Moreover, these continuous incremental hikes should be fairly investigated and regulated by consumer protection authorities to ensure that customers are not being taken advantage of by the utility services.

Riaz Ahmed

Lahore

countries. These institutions play a critical role in providing analysis and evidence-driven insight through rigorous research work. Their influence is evident in how these nations swiftly respond to emerging challenges, be it geopolitical shifts, the climate crisis or economic uncertainty.

In Pakistan, too, the role of think tanks can no longer be overlooked. There are many that have made commendable research contributions and provided policy solutions on issues ranging from national security to climate change and sustainable growth. However, a major challenge lies in the disconnect between these research institutions and actual policymaking.

Despite generating valuable knowledge, their findings remain confined to journals and seminars, and are rarely translated into action due to lack of institutional coordination, limited political will, and short-term governance priorities.

This underutilisation not only wastes intellectual resources, but also deprives the country of informed, long-term solutions to recurring challenges. With Pakistan confronting growing internal and external challenges, the demand for evidence-informed policymaking has never been greater.

Strengthening think tanks with consistent backing and institutional autonomy is not just an intellectual investment; it is a strategic necessity for the country's future.

Khizra Rashad

Lahore



Role of think tanks

GIVEN today's complex global landscape, think tanks have emerged as a national necessity for informed policy progress. These institutions have become a vital engine for strategic thinking and policy innovation in the fields of international affairs, economic reforms, strategic studies, fiscal planning, climate governance and foreign policy analysis.

Across leading nations, organisations like Adam Smith Institute in the United Kingdom, Brookings Institution in the United States, and the China Institutes of Contemporary International Relations (CICIR) in China are deeply embedded in the policy architecture of their respective

motorisation once incomes cross \$2,500 per capita. Until then, volumes will remain sub-scale, limiting economies of scale.

Exports, too, are not constrained by capability. The real barrier is Brand Pakistan. Security incidents like the recent Quetta blast, policy unpredictability, and lack of free trade agreements (FTAs) deter foreign buyers from sourcing here; not the quality of the vendors.

Liberalising used-car imports would only worsen the matters: starving vendors of demand, destroying jobs, and creating a permanent import burden. Successful peers, like India and Thailand, only opened their markets after achieving scale.

What Pakistan really needs is not shock therapy, but stability: a cascading tariff structure, regulated used-car inflows, stronger financing, and export facilitation. The local auto industry is not a white elephant; it is one of the few engines that can drive Pakistan's industrial future.

M. Shuja ul Haq Siddiqui

Vice-Chairman

Pakistan Association of Automotive Parts and Accessories Manufacturers
Karachi

Training wheels

THIS refers to the article "Removing the auto sector's training wheels" (B&F, Sept 8), which portrayed Pakistan's auto industry as a 'white elephant' that has failed despite decades of protection.

While consumer frustrations with affordability are understandable, the said write-up has overlooked some important facts and risks undermining the sector. Pakistan's auto-parts ecosystem supports 1.83 million jobs, sustains 1,200 local suppliers, and substitutes \$1.25 billion worth of imports annually.

Vendors have invested over Rs100 billion in tooling and plants, producing globally certified components supplied to Japanese, South Korean and Middle Eastern markets.

High car prices are a symptom of macro-economic realities, not industrial inefficiency. With per capita income below \$2,000, double-digit interest rates, heavy taxation, and a weak rupee, affordability is bound to remain low. Countries see mass



Financial probe and undue legal shelter

PAKISTAN'S banking sector seems to be grappling with a growing challenge as borrowers accused of fraud and wilful default are using the courts to stall investigations by the Federal Investigation Agency (FIA). While these borrowers secure stay orders or even outright quashment of FIRs from high courts, a string of Supreme Court judgments clearly states that civil disputes should not halt criminal investigations, especially when allegations of fraud and misuse of funds are involved.

The conflict between these legal actions is not just a procedural matter; it is a critical threat to financial stability, accountability and the rule of law.

The core legal issue is whether a bank's recourse to civil recovery, such as filing a suit in a banking court, should prevent the FIA from investigating a parallel criminal offence. The Lahore High Court, in a notable full-bench decision (CLD 375), made a critical distinction. It held that simple 'civil default' (failing to repay a loan) requires prior civil adjudication, meaning a court must first declare the borrower a defaulter.

However, the court also recognised that allegations of 'fraud', 'misuse of funds', or 'forgery' are independently cognisable criminal offences that the FIA can and should investigate. Despite this clear differentiation, banks often face blanket restraining orders from high courts that effectively stall investigative action, regardless of the nature of the alleged offence. This creates a loophole that allows borrowers to use legal manoeuvring to avoid accountability.

The Supreme Court has consistently and unequivocally sided with the need to allow criminal investigations to proceed. In a series of landmark judgments, the court has provided a clear roadmap

that banks and the FIA must follow. The most recent and arguably the most significant precedent related to a case (PLD 2023 SC 265) in which the Supreme Court reversed a high court decision that had quashed an FIA FIR, stating that quashing an FIR at the very beginning of an investigation is an extraordinary remedy to be used only in the rarest of cases.

The apex court emphasised that an accused person's proper remedy is to seek discharge or acquittal during the trial, not to prematurely block the investigation.

The principle that civil and criminal proceedings are not mutually exclusive has been reaffirmed repeatedly (2017 SCMR 390; 2011 SCMR 1813), and the court has held that the existence of a civil dispute or pending recovery suit does not immunise a person from criminal liability. The two types of proceedings can, and often must, run concurrently.

This is quite a vital point for banks to emphasise: pursuing a civil remedy for a loan default does not preclude the FIA from investigating the fraudulent actions that led to it. In other cases (PLD 1971 SC 677), the Supreme Court has clarified that a high court's inherent powers do not extend to restraining an executive action like an FIA investigation unless there is clear evidence of malfeasance or a complete lack of jurisdiction.

The narrative must be forceful and clear: civil and criminal remedies are parallel, not mutually exclusive. Allowing the FIA to at least complete its inquiry and collect evidence is crucial for preventing the destruction of records and the concealment of assets. The integrity of our financial system depends on our ability to hold individuals accountable for their acts.

Muhammad Afnan Malik
Lahore

Bridges, roads damaged as flash floods hit Chitral, Shangla



A ROAD in Ashrait village near Lowari tunnel, which was washed away by flash flood in the early hours on Tuesday, being cleared for vehicular traffic. (Right) A portion of Belkanai-Lilownai Road in Shangla swept away by hill torrent. — Dawn

No casualties reported; revenue teams dispatched for damage assessment; rain to continue until 19th

Dawn Report

CHITRAL/SHANGLA: Torrential rains caused flash floods in Lower Chitral and Shangla, damaging bridges, roads, houses and farmland on Tuesday.

The southern parts of Lower Chitral district from Drosh to Lowari Pass encompassing the valleys of Sheshi Koh, Arsoon, Damil and Jinjirait Koh received heaviest rain of the season in the early hours of Tuesday triggering flash floods that disrupted life in the area.

The flash floods also hit Chitral-Peshawar Road, the major artery connecting Chitral with the rest of the country, at a length of more than 30 kilomet-

res from Drosh to Lowari tunnel, stranding hundreds of passengers in Lowari Pass, who passed the night in vehicles.

The roads leading to the valleys of Arsoon, Sheshi Koh and Jinjirait Koh were also hit by the floods closing them for vehicular traffic as well as pedestrians.

No casualty was reported from any part of the affected areas, while heavy loss was reportedly caused to farmlands and orchards as well as the low-lying pastures, which were washed away by the flood.

A number of families had moved to the safer places in the distant places of Sheshi Koh Valley and Jinjirait Koh, while a number of homes were partially damaged by the flood as per initial survey.

Lower Chitral deputy commissioner Mohammad Hashim Azeem told *Dawn* that Chitral-Peshawar Road and Sheshi Koh Valley roads were opened for light traffic, while Arsoon Road and Janjarit Koh Road were yet to be reopened.

He said no casualties had been reported from the floods and teams of revenue staff had been dispatched to make detailed assessment of damage to homes and property.

Meanwhile, Al-Khidmat Foundation volunteers reached some of the affected spots with food and non-food items in the far-flung villages of Sheshi Koh.

Elsewhere, heavy rain caused massive destruction in Kana tehsil of Shangla district on Tuesday morning sweeping away bridges in Belkanai and Damorai areas.

According to the locals, heavy rain coupled with strong winds hit Kana tehsil's upper union councils Olandar, Belkanai and Damorai, where two crucial bridges connecting the areas with the rest of the district were swept away.

The heavy rain lashed the district on Monday night and continued on Tuesday.

Irfan Babu, a local resident, said rains caused severe damage to the standing crops.

He said the Lilonai-Tabulkanai Road had been blocked by landslides at

Bata Tangi.

He demanded that the district administration immediately restore the road so that people can bring ration to their homes as the Met Department had predicted more rains till Sept 19.

Jamal Khan, a resident of Dunkkacha Puran, demanded that the government speed up the rehabilitation work in the flood-hit areas.

Meanwhile, rainwater inundated a government primary school situated in the constituency of provincial minister for elementary and secondary education Faisal Khan Tarakai as heavy downpour hit the Swabi district in the early hours of Tuesday.

Haji Mumtaz Khan, a resident of Swabi city, told *Dawn* that local education authorities failed to make arrangements for draining rainwater from the building.

When contacted, district education officer Hafiz Mohammad Nawaz, told *Dawn* that they had not received any complaint about rainwater accumulating in the school.

Constable martyred, ASI hurt in Charsadda attack

Page 8

By Our Correspondent

CHARSADDA: A police constable was martyred and an assistant sub-inspector suffered injuries when proclaimed offenders opened fire on a police party during a raid in Darab Majoki area of Parang here on Tuesday.

As a result of the firing, motorway police post in-charge Qaiser Khan was seriously injured, while SHO Parang's gunman, constable Fasihuddin, was martyred on the spot.

District police officer Mohammad Waqas, deputy commissioner Dr Azmatullah Khan Wazir, and other police officers visited the hospital to enquire after the injured ASI.

DPO Waqas said on a tip-off that a group of proclaimed offenders from Peshawar were present in Darab Majoki area, a police team led by DSP Zardad Khan, and also including ASI Qaiser Khan, conducted a raid.

During the operation, he said the outlaws opened fire on the police party, killing SHO Parang's gunman Fasihuddin on the spot, and injuring ASI Qaiser critically. After the exchange of fire, the assailants managed to escape.

The martyred and injured policemen were shifted to the District Headquarters Hospital, Charsadda.

The DPO said a search operation had been launched to arrest the attackers.

SHO Parang police station Fazal Daud got registered a case against the outlaws – Shah Saud, Rokhail, Yasin and Saddam – under section 7-ATA, and 302, 353 and other provisions.

Tribal elder's son abducted in S. Waziristan

Page 8

By Our Correspondent

SOUTH WAZIRISTAN: Terrorists abducted son of a tribal elder, Malik Raz Mohammad, from Gul Dona Ghundai area of Birmal tehsil of Lower South Waziristan on Tuesday.

According to police sources, a local commander of a proscribed terror outfit had issued threats to Malik Raz a few days ago. They said the abduction appears to be directly linked to those threats, leaving the family and the wider community deeply alarmed.

The incident has drawn strong condemnation from local residents and tribal elders, who termed the act cowardly and barbaric. They said the militants were not only playing with human lives but also sabotaging traditional tribal values and local peace-building efforts.

The community members urged the government and law-enforcement agencies to take immediate action for the safe recovery of the abducted youth and to ensure stern punishment for those responsible.

This is not the first time Malik Raz Mohammad has been targeted. In January 2024, his vehicle was attacked in a bomb blast that left him critically injured along with his brother and son.

Businessman deprived of Rs1.7m

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PESHAWAR: Armed robbers struck in the heart of the city on Tuesday, making off with Rs1.7 million in cash during a daring daylight robbery in the Gulbahar area.

According to the police, two gunmen riding a motorcycle intercepted businessman Azhar Masood, a resident of Sheikh Abad, as he was heading to Gulbahar from his car trading outlet in Garhi Qamardin area.

The robbers held him at gunpoint, seized the cash, and managed to escape.

The police have registered a case and launched an investigation.

However, the ease with which the suspects carried out the heist has once again highlighted the surge in street crime across the provincial capital, leaving residents questioning whether Peshawar has been left at the mercy of criminals.

Meanwhile, two unidentified motorcycle-borne robbers intercepted a lawyer at gunpoint on Dalazak Road and snatched his expensive smartphone before fleeing the scene. — APP

Govt machinery at standstill as employees' strike continues

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By Mohammad Ashfaq

PESHAWAR: The government employees continued their strike on Tuesday for the second consecutive day, bringing the entire government machinery at the civil secretariat here along with attached departments and directorates across Khyber Pakhtunkhwa to a standstill.

They observed a strike against the storming of the education secretary's office by special assistant to the chief minister on relief Naik Mohammad along with armed men.

Besides staging a day-long sit-in outside the elementary and secondary education department at the civil secretariat, the employees also demonstrated demanding the immediate removal of aide to the CM Naik Mohammad and registration of an FIR against him.

Following the directives of elementary and secondary education department (ESED) secretary Mohammad Khalid, the employees of the education department's attached formations worked from home.

The attached formations of the education department including provincial directorate and district education

offices wore a deserted look due to physical absence of the employees.

Officials told *Dawn* that the incident involving special assistant to the chief minister on relief Naik Mohammad took place last Friday when he barged into education secretary Mohammad Khalid's office at the civil secretariat along with armed guards and other persons to pressure the top official into withdrawing transfer orders for North Waziristan's district education officer (female).

According to a "situation report," by the education department after the attack of armed persons led by the special assistant, "The group unlawfully intruded into department premises, creating a situation of intimidation and harassment."

President of the Provincial Management Service Association Noman Wazir told *Dawn* that the employees observed the strike from 10pm to 2pm.

He said senior bureaucrats delivered their speeches amid sloganeering against the aide to the CM and in favour of the education secretary.

"Our strike will continue until the accept-

ance of our demands, which include the removal of the special assistant and the registration of FIR against him.

If strict action is not taken, all influential persons will get the courage to storm the offices of government employees at will," he said.

Addressing protesters, secretary of the livestock department Tahir

Orakzai said the government employees were committed to protecting the people's interest in line with rules and regulations.

"The government servants have got fed up with the day-to-day unneces-

sary interventions of politicians in their affairs," he said.

Mr Orakzai said that the government servants were competent people, who were recruited through proper procedures but they weren't allowed to carry out proper planning and executive schemes on

their own.

He said the elected members were respectable for government servants and whenever they visited government offices, they're treated with honour and respect but it didn't mean that the politicians would disrespect government servants.

Italian court orders extradition of Ukrainian in Nord Stream case

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ROME: An Italian court on Tuesday ordered a Ukrainian man arrested over the 2022 sabotage of the Nord Stream gas pipelines linking Russia with Europe to be extradited to Germany to face charges.

Serhii Kuznietsov, arrested in Italy last month on a German warrant, denies involvement and will appeal the ruling, his lawyer Nicola Canestrini said.

Kuznietsov, who says he was a member of the Ukrainian armed forces at the time, is accused of being part of a cell which placed explosives on the underwater pipelines in September 2022.

He faces up to 15 years in jail if found guilty in Germany, according to the ruling by the court in the northern Italian city of Bologna.

The pipelines that for years shipped Russian gas to Europe were damaged by huge blasts just months after Russia's February 2022 invasion of Ukraine. Western powers who back Kyiv were initially quick to blame Russia, which in turn accused them.

German investigations have identified a Ukrainian cell of five men and one woman as the perpetrators of the blasts.

When he was arrested, German prosecutors said Kuznietsov had used forged identity documents to charter a yacht, which departed from the German city of Rostock to carry out the attacks.

Kuznietsov says he was in Ukraine at the time of the explosions, and will "appeal... the Bologna court of appeal's decision to order his surrender to Germany", his lawyer said in a statement. Italy's Court of Cassation is expected to rule on the case in around a month's time, Canestrini said. In the meantime, Kuznietsov is being held in a high-security prison in northern Italy.

In court, according to Tuesday's ruling, Kuznietsov's team argued that even if he had been involved, he could not face the charges as they stand as he was a soldier following orders at a time of war. Canestrini insisted the "military nature of the alleged acts entails functional immunity" under international law.—AFP



Russia's President Vladimir Putin tours an exhibition of military equipment while inspecting the joint military drills with Belarus.—AFP

Moscow, Minsk rehearse launch of nuclear weapons

Putin says 100,000 troops are taking part in Belarus-Russia drills

MOSCOW: Russia and Belarus are rehearsing the launch of Russian tactical nuclear weapons as part of joint war games, Belarusian leader Alexander Lukashenko said on Tuesday.

State media quoted the Belarusian chief of staff as saying that the exercises also featured Russia's Oreshnik hypersonic missile, which it test-fired last year in the war with Ukraine.

Russia and Belarus are ending five days of war games codenamed Zapad (West) in a show of force they say is to test combat readiness but which has unnerved some surrounding countries. Dressed in military attire, Russian President Vladimir Putin met with top military officials on Tuesday in Russia's Nizhny Novgorod region, where some of the drills took place.

He said 100,000 troops were participating in the Zapad (West) joint drills with Belarus, during a surprise visit to the exercise, part of which took place close to NATO borders. Minsk earlier said only 7,000 troops were participating in the Belarusian stage of the drills, which was observed by US army representatives.

"Today we are conducting the final part of the Zapad 2025 strategic exercise," said Putin, wearing a military uniform, adding: "100,000 servicemen are taking part." Russian news agencies reported, citing the Kremlin, that soldiers from India, Iran, Bangladesh, as well as Burkina Faso, Congo and Mali were participating in the exercise, which had up to now been advertised as a joint Russian-Belarusian drill.

The Zapad manoeuvres have put NATO's eastern members on high alert following the downing of Russian drones in Poland last week, which has prompted Warsaw to shut the border with Belarus. Putin added that the drills were aimed at exercising

"repelling potential aggression against the Union State," referring to the allied entity of Russia and Belarus.

According to Polish Prime Minister Donald Tusk, the drills are designed to simulate occupation of the Suwalki corridor, a strategically important area in Poland. Warsaw said it would station around 40,000 troops near the Belarus border for the duration of the drills.

Russia said it had exercised a launch of its latest Zircon supersonic navy missile from a frigate in the Barents Sea on Sunday. Nuclear weapons deployment planning was also drilled during the Zapad exercise, according to the Belarusian army.

Around 200,000 troops participated in the 2021 edition of Zapad, staged just months before Moscow sent forces into Ukraine.

The drills were to ensure the "unconditional protection of the sovereignty and territorial integrity of the Union State," Putin said, referring to the alliance of Russia and Belarus.—Agencies

Smoke-dried bodies could be 'oldest mummies' study

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BANGKOK: Some ancient societies in China and southeast Asia appear to have smoke-dried their dead, effectively mummi-fying them thousands of years earlier than their Egyptian counterparts, new research has found.

While the bandage-bound bodies of ancient Egypt date back perhaps as far as 4,500 years ago, the oldest previously known examples of mummification are from ancient Chilean societies.

There, the dry air of the Atacama coastline allowed

for natural mummification by drying. But the bodies retrieved by researchers from China and southeast Asia came largely from humid regions.

The scientists were initially intrigued by the contorted positions of skeletons found in burial sites in China, Vietnam, the Philippines, Laos, Thailand, Malaysia and Indonesia. The remains appeared to have scorch marks in some places, but in patterns inconsistent with attempts at cremation.—AFP

Afghan jailed for killing policeman in Germany

STUTTGART: An Afghan man was sentenced to life in prison on Tuesday for a stabbing spree in Germany last year that killed a police officer and left five people wounded.

The 26-year-old, only partially named as Sulaiman A. and found to be a supporter of the militant Islamic State group, committed the knife attack in May 2024 in the western city of Mannheim.

The court convicted him of murder, attempted murder and dangerous bodily harm and judged his crimes to be especially grave, which virtually rules out early release.

Sulaiman A. used a large hunting knife in the attack which targeted a rally by Pax Europa, a group that campaigns against radical Islam.

He initially attacked a speaker and other demonstrators, then stabbed a police officer who rushed in to help before being shot and wounded by

police himself. The critically wounded police officer, 29-year-old Rouven L., died two days later of his injuries.

Many Germans were especially shocked as a video of the attack circulating online showed the officer being repeatedly stabbed in the back of the head. Presiding Judge Herbert Anderer said that the attacker wanted to cause "the greatest possible harm in the form of as many deaths as possible". He also wanted to kill police officers as representatives of the German state and planned to die a "martyr's death" and "to enter paradise", the judge said.

Sulaiman A. arrived in Germany in 2013 aged just 14, together with his brother but without their parents. They were denied asylum but, as unaccompanied minors, granted stays of deportation and permanent residency, and initially placed in care facilities, media reports said.—AFP

India's Maoist fighters 'suspend armed struggle'

Page 9

NEW DELHI: India's Maoist fighters announced on Tuesday that they will be unilaterally suspending their "armed struggle" and are ready for dialogue with authorities, following the government's all-out offensive to crush the decades-long conflict.

"Because of the changed world order and national situation, and because of the continuous appeals from the Prime Minister, Home Minister, and senior police officials, we are deciding to suspend armed struggle," a spokesman for the Communist Party of India (Maoist) rebel group said in a statement.

"We are ready to start dialogue" with the government, added the spokesman.

There was no immediate government response to the Maoist announcement.

India is waging an intense offensive against the last remaining traces of the Naxalite rebellion, named after the village in the foothills of the Himalayas where the Maoist-inspired guerilla movement began nearly six decades ago.

More than 12,000 rebels, soldiers and civilians have been killed since a handful of villagers rose up against their feudal lords there in 1967.—AFP

New Delhi's toxic air is turning iconic Red Fort black, study says

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Monitoring Desk

SEVERE air pollution in Indian capital Delhi has led to the formation of “black crusts” on the walls of the Red Fort, one of the city’s most iconic Mughal-era monuments, a study has found.

According to the BBC, researchers found that the crusts — deposits formed due to chemical interactions between pollutants and the walls of the red sandstone fort — were between 0.05mm and 0.5mm thick, and could damage its intricate carvings if no action was taken. The study is the first of its kind to compre-

hensively examine the effects of air pollution on the 17th Century monument.

One of the world’s most polluted cities, Delhi frequently makes headlines for its worsening air quality, especially during the winter months.

Conservationists have frequently warned about the detrimental impact of pollution on heritage structures in the capital and a few other states.

In 2018, the Supreme Court said that the Taj Mahal — the famous 17th Century mausoleum built from white marble — had turned yellow and greenish-brown due to air and water pollution and urged the Uttar Pradesh state govern-

ment to take steps to conserve it.

The study on the Red Fort, published in the peer-reviewed open access scientific journal *Heritage* in June, was conducted between 2021 and 2023 by researchers in India and Italy.

The Red Fort, built by Mughal Emperor Shah Jahan, is one of Delhi’s most iconic heritage monuments and a popular tourist attraction. India’s first Prime Minister Jawaharlal Nehru hoisted the national flag from the fort on 16 August 1947, a day after independence from Britain was declared. Since then, prime ministers have been

delivering speeches on Independence Day from the ramparts of the fort.

The researchers studied Delhi’s air quality data between 2021 and 2023. Then they scraped off the black crust found on various walls of the fort and examined its composition.

They found that particulate matter and other pollutants in the air had caused the black sediment to form on the fort’s walls and also damaged other architectural elements such as vaults, arches and delicate stone carvings. The researchers also found evidence of blistering and flaking on the walls.



BLACK crusts seen on the upper and lower windows of the fort.—Courtesy BBC News

“PM2.5 and PM10 [types of particulate matter] are widely recognised as significant con-

tributors to the soiling of surfaces exposed to ambient air. This phenomenon occurs

when particulate matter settles and accumulates over time, leading to visible discolouration and blackening of these surfaces,” the study notes. The study recommends the timely implementation of conservation strategies to protect the fort.

“The formation of a black crust is a progressive phenomenon that usually begins with a thin black layer or deposit, which can be removed, at least in the early stages,” the study notes.

It also says that stone protectives or sealants could be applied to highly-affected areas to slow down or prevent the formation of black crusts.



PASSERS-BY take photos of the *New York Times* building after President Donald Trump filed the defamation lawsuit.—AFP

Trump sues *NYT* for \$15bn in latest attack on media

WASHINGTON: Donald Trump filed a \$15 billion defamation lawsuit against *The New York Times* on Monday, adding to the US president's growing list of legal attacks on news organisations he accuses of bias against him.

Trump, 79, has intensified his long-established hostility toward the media since his return to the White House, repeatedly badmouthing journalists critical of his administration, restricting access and bringing lawsuits demanding huge amounts of compensation.

In his suit filed in federal court in Florida, Trump accuses *The New York Times* of a "decades-long pattern" of smears driven by feelings of "actual malice."

The Times reported last week that Trump had threatened legal action against it in relation to its articles on a lewd birthday note he allegedly gave to sex offender Jeffrey Epstein.

A copy of the alleged note was later released by US lawmakers. The Republican president has denied authoring the note. "*The New York Times* has been allowed to freely lie, smear, and defame me for far too long, and that

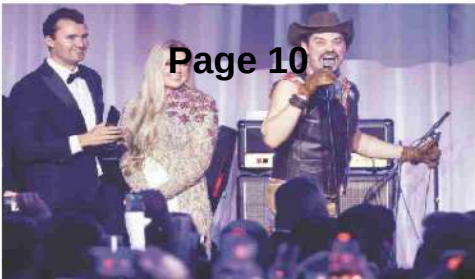
stops, NOW!" he wrote on his Truth Social platform.

The lawsuit also named four *New York Times* reporters and the publisher Penguin Random House as defendants, according to an 85-page complaint filed in the US District Court for Florida's Middle District.

The document cited three articles that came out between September and October last year, and a book by Pulitzer Prize-winning reporters Russ Buettner and Susanne Craig also published around that time.

"The Book and Articles are part of a decades-long pattern by the *New York Times* of intentional and malicious defamation against President Trump," read the complaint, which was dated Monday.

"*The Times* has become a leading, and unapologetic, purveyor of falsehoods against President Trump on the legacy media landscape." In a statement posted on X, *The Times* said Trump's case "has no merit." "It lacks any legitimate legal claims and instead is an attempt to stifle and discourage independent reporting. *The New York Times* will not be deterred by intimidation tactics," it added.—AFP



CHARLIE Kirk (left) and his wife Erika Lane Frantzve watch as The Village People perform during an event of the Turning Point USA in Washington on Jan 19.—AFP/file

Suspect in Charlie Kirk killing charged with murder

PROVO: The suspect in the murder of prominent US conservative political activist Charlie Kirk has been formally charged with his murder, prosecutors in Utah announced on Tuesday.

Kirk, a close ally of President Donald Trump, was shot dead last week during a speaking event on a Utah university campus. He was the founder of the influential conservative youth political group Turning Point USA.

Authorities said 22-year-old Tyler Robinson used a rifle to shoot Kirk with a single bullet to the neck from a rooftop. He was arrested after a 33-hour manhunt.

"After reviewing the evidence that law enforcement has collected thus far, I am... charging Tyler James Robinson, age 22 with the following crimes," Utah County attorney Jeff Gray told a press conference.

"Count one, aggravated murder, a capital offense, for intentionally or knowingly causing the death of Charlie Kirk under circumstances that created a great risk of death to others." Six other charges include obstruction of justice and witness tampering, allegedly for ordering his room-mate to stay silent.

"I am filing a notice of intent to seek the death penalty," Gray added.

"I do not take this decision lightly, and it is a decision I have made independently as county attorney based solely on the available evidence and circumstances and nature of the crime."

Kirk, a father of two, used his audiences on TikTok, Instagram and YouTube to build support for conservative talking points, including strong criticism of the transgender rights movement.—AFP

No info that Epstein trafficked women to others: FBI

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WASHINGTON: FBI Director Kash Patel said on Tuesday that there is no “credible information” in law enforcement files that convicted sex offender Jeffrey Epstein trafficked young women to other individuals.

“There is no credible information, none,” Patel said at a Senate Judiciary Committee hearing. “If there were I would bring the case yesterday that he trafficked to other individuals.” Some of Donald Trump’s fiercest supporters have tracked the Epstein case for years, believing “deep state” elites have been protecting Epstein associates in the Democratic Party and Hollywood. Patel’s comments come after he angered many Trump loyalists with a memo in July that effectively closed the investigation into Epstein, who died in a New York jail cell in 2019 while awaiting trial for trafficking of underage girls.

In testimony before the committee, Patel also said an investigation is ongoing into members of an online gaming room frequented by Utah man Tyler Robinson, the alleged assassin of conservative activist Charlie Kirk. “There are a number of individuals that are currently being investigated and interrogated, and a number yet to be investigated and interrogated, specific to that chat room,” he said. Asked by a senator whether others could have been involved, Patel said: “Yes sir.” Patel came under fire from Democrats on the Senate panel for a purge of the FBI ranks of scores of agents who worked on criminal cases involving Trump or were perceived to be disloyal to the Republican president.

Senator Dick Durbin, the ranking Democrat on the committee, accused Patel of inflicting “untold damage on the FBI” and putting “national security and public safety at risk” with an “unprecedented purge of FBI officials.”—AFP

Pakistan sees 'dangerous escalation'; UNHRC urges accountability for Israel's Qatar attack

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KARACHI: Pakistan warned of "dangerous escalation" as the United Nations and a long line of countries on Tuesday denounced Israel's attack on Qatar last week, demanding "accountability".

On Sept 9, Israel targeted Hamas leaders gathered in Doha to discuss a new US ceasefire proposal for Gaza. That strike "was a shocking breach of international law", UN rights chief Volker Turk said during an urgent debate at the UN Human Rights Council about the strike.

Denouncing the attack as "an assault on regional peace and stability", he urged "accountability for unlawful killings".

His words were echoed by Qatar and dozens of country representatives who took the floor during the three-hour debate.

Qatari International Cooperation Minister Maryam bint Ali bin Nasser Al-Misnad slammed Israel's "treacherous attack" and demanded that the international community "take practical steps to hold the aggres-

sors accountable and prevent their impunity".

"This attack was not an isolated incident, but rather was part of a broader campaign aimed at distorting Qatar's role and obstructing its diplomatic efforts," she said.

Pakistan's ambassador Bilal Ahmad warned that "this unjustifiable and unprovoked attack constitutes a dangerous escalation".

China's ambassador Chen Xu said his country "firmly rejects

and categorically condemns" the September 9 attack, which he charged was "a deliberate attempt to derail the negotiation process".

Some of the harshest criticism came from South Africa, which has brought a case against Israel before the International Court of Justice, accusing it of committing genocide in Gaza.

The attack "strikes against the very heart of mediation processes", ambassador Mxolisi Nkosi told the council, adding

that it "demonstrates that Israel does not want to end its genocidal war against the Palestinian people".

"It is time for the international community to demonstrate through practical countermeasures that Israel does not enjoy some form of special immunity from accountability."

Neither Israel nor its main ally, the United States, which both disengaged from the council earlier this year, was present for the urgent debate.—Dawn Report

US, Syria working on ‘security understandings’ with Israel

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Damascus withdraws heavy weapons from country's south

DAMASCUS: Syria's foreign ministry said Damascus and Washington were working to reach security understandings with Israel as part of a roadmap for stability announced earlier on Tuesday with US and Jordanian support for violence-hit Sweida province.

“The United States, in consultation with the Syrian government, will work to reach security understandings with Israel concerning southern Syria that address the legitimate security concerns of both Syria and Israel while emphasising Syria's sovereignty and territorial integrity,” the foreign ministry said in a statement outlining the roadmap. Even a modest agreement would be a feat, the sources said, pointing to Israel's tough stance during months of talks and Syria's weakened position after sectarian bloodshed in its south inflamed calls for partition. Intelligence sources

said Syria's proposal aims to secure the withdrawal of Israeli troops from territory seized in recent months, to reinstate a demilitarised buffer zone agreed in a 1974 truce, and to halt Israeli air strikes and ground incursions into Syria.

The sources said talks had not addressed the status of the Golan Heights, which Israel seized in a 1967 war. A Syrian source familiar with Damascus's position said it would be left “for the future.”

The two countries have technically been at war since the creation of Israel in 1948, despite periodic armistices. Syria does not recognise the state of Israel.

After months of encroaching into the demilitarised zone, Israel abandoned the 1974 truce on Dec 8, the day a rebel offensive ousted Syria's then-president Bashar al-Assad. It struck Syrian military assets and sent troops to within 20 kilometres of Damascus. Israel has shown reluctance during the closed-door talks to relinquish those gains, the sources said.

A State Department official said Washington “continues to support

any efforts that will bring lasting stability and peace between Israel, Syria and its neighbors.” The official did not answer questions on whether the US wanted to announce a breakthrough during the General Assembly.

Heavy weapons withdrawn

Syrian forces have withdrawn heavy weapons from the country's south where Israel has demanded a demilitarised zone, a military official said on Tuesday, as Damascus announced a roadmap for restoring calm in a violence-hit southern province. A week of sectarian bloodshed in Druze-majority Sweida province erupted on July 13 with clashes between Druze fighters and Bedouins but rapidly escalated, drawing in government forces and tribal fighters from other parts of Syria.

Israel, which has its own Druze community, intervened with air strikes on government targets, saying it was acting to defend the minority group as well as to enforce its demands for south Syria's demilitarisation.—Agencies

S. Arabia, UK launch plan to boost maritime security off Yemen

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Israel strikes Houthi-held port after evacuation warnings

RIYADH/HODEIDA: Saudi Arabia and Britain launched a partnership on Tuesday to strengthen Yemen's coastguard in the Red Sea and Gulf of Aden, where Houthi rebels have stepped up attacks on commercial shipping.

Under the agreement announced at a news conference in Riyadh, the coastguard of Yemen's internationally recognised government would be trained and equipped to tackle threats that also include piracy, human-trafficking and smuggling.

The initiative received funding worth several million dollars from more than 35 countries, including Australia, Canada, Japan and the United States, as well as Gulf nations and the European Union, according to the British embassy.

Saudi Arabia pledged \$4 million, said its ambassador to Yemen, Mohammed Al Jaber.

The Iran-backed Houthis, who control swathes of Yemen, have launched missiles and drones targeting Israel and Red Sea shipping throughout the Gaza war, saying they are acting in solidarity with Palestinians.

Japan's ambassador to Yemen, Yoichi Nakashima, stressed the importance of the Yemeni government controlling its coastline, though he cautioned this would not necessarily reduce Houthi attacks.

"We can see this as a first step, to be followed by others," he said.

Israeli attacks

Israel struck Hodeida port on Tuesday, saying it targeted infrastructure used by the rebels, who

reported a dozen strikes on the area.

Israel has stepped up attacks on the Houthis, killing their prime minister and nearly half of his cabinet last month and leaving dozens dead in strikes last week mainly targeting the rebels' military media operation.

The rebels' Al-Masirah television said "12 Israeli enemy air strikes targeted the port of Hodeida".

Military spokesman Yahya Saree said the group's air defences were "currently confronting Israeli enemy aircraft launching an aggression against our country".

The Israeli military said it struck "a military infrastructure site belonging to the Houthi terrorist regime at the Hodeida port in Yemen".

It also accused the group of using the port "for the transfer of weapons supplied by the Iranian regime, in order to execute attacks against the State of Israel and its allies".

The Israeli military's Arabic-language spokesman, Avichay Adraee, had warned of the strikes earlier, saying they would be in response to Houthi military activity and urging "everyone in Hodeida port and the vessels anchored there to evacuate".

In a statement on X, Israeli Defence Minister Israel Katz warned the Houthis would "continue to suffer blows and pay painful prices for any attempt to attack the State of Israel". Since the Gaza war erupted in October 2023, the Houthis have launched repeated drone and missile attacks against Israel claiming solidarity with the Palestinians.

In response, Israel has carried out rounds of retaliatory strikes in Yemen, mainly targeting infrastructure such as ports, power stations and the international airport in Sanaa.—AFP



SANAA: Mourners carry coffins of members of the Houthi military media, killed in last week's Israeli air strikes, during their funeral.—Reuters

Hollywood icon Robert Redford dies at 89

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ONCE dismissed as 'just another 'California blonde', Robert Redford remained a legend of the silver screen for several decades.—AFP

aged millionaire who offers to buy sex in *Indecent Proposal*.

He used the millions he made to launch the Sundance Institute and Festival in the 1970s, promoting independent filmmaking long before small and quirky were fashionable.

He never won the best actor Oscar, but his first outing as a director — the 1980 family

drama *Ordinary People* — won Oscars for best picture and best director.

Yet he remained best known for the two early movies he made with Paul Newman: the 1969 western caper *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid*, and *The Sting* (1973), both of which became classics.

Despite their chemistry and

long personal friendship, Redford was never to team up again with Newman, who died in 2008.

Intensely private, Redford bought land in remote Utah in the early 1970s for his family retreat and enjoyed a level of privacy unknown to most superstars.

He was married for more than 25 years to his first wife, before their divorce in 1985. In 2009, he married for a second time, to German artist and longtime partner Sibylle Szaggars.

Redford used his star status to seek out challenging film projects and to quietly champion environmental causes such as the Natural Resources Defence Council and the National Wildlife Federation.

Although he never showed an interest in entering politics, he often espoused a liberal viewpoint. In a 2017 interview, during the presidency of Donald Trump, he told *Esquire* magazine that “politics is in a very dark place right now” and that Trump

should “quit for our benefit”.

Born in the Los Angeles beach city of Santa Monica on Aug 18, 1936, to what he described as a “lower working class family”, Redford landed a college baseball scholarship but lost it after spending too much time partying.

Deciding he wanted to be an artist, he moved to Italy and later New York to study painting. He enrolled in drama school to try his hand at theatrical set design, but was persuaded to take to the stage and by 1959 he was a full-time performer on Broadway and later found work on television.

He made his movie debut in 1962 in a low-budget film, *Warhunt*, but first won attention in *Barefoot in the Park* (1967), opposite Jane Fonda.

He turned down the role taken by Dustin Hoffman in *The Graduate* and held out for *Butch Cassidy and the Sundance Kid*. In 2001, he won an honorary, or lifetime achievement, Oscar.—Reuters

Pakistan signals support for united anti-Israel front

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Continued from Page 1

[sic], but for peaceful purpose[s], for stopping the aggressor, for stopping the occupier, for stopping someone who just doesn't listen."

When asked where nuclear-armed Pakistan would stand, Mr Dar responded: "Pakistan, obviously, as a member of the ummah, would discharge its duty."

When pressed to elaborate, he clarified that Pakistan saw nuclear weapons only for deterrence and didn't intend to use them. "We have no intention of using it; it is only a deterrence."

"But Pakistan has a very large, known, very effective army, very effective air force, very effective navy ... We have proved that we can beat [our opponent] even conventionally, if challenged," he maintained.

The interviewer then brought up a recent debate at the UN Security Council where Israel had invoked a 2011 attack within Pakistan to kill Osama Bin Laden in a bid to justify its attacks in Gaza.

"So if now Pakistan comes under attack, from a country like the United States, for instance, would Pakistan act differently [than it did in 2011]?" he

asked.

"We would not allow the breach of our territorial integrity, no matter by whom, be it the smallest or the largest country. We would respond. But I don't see any reason why the US or any other country would do it. India did it. You saw what happened to them," replied Dar.

Need for UN reform

Mr Dar highlighted that Israel had attacked multiple countries in the Middle East and said that international laws, international humanitarian rules and UN Security Council resolutions seemed to have "no effect

on one country, which is repeatedly doing what it feels like".

"That means [the] multi-lateral system needs very serious reforms right now ... This is the need of the hour. I think the UN Security Council, as well as the UN system itself needs very serious reforms.

To a question about whether Israel could attack Pakistan next after Qatar, Dar reminded that India had tried that and Israel "gave it full support according to our information" and the "world saw that the claim is exposed".

"We are ready. Again, I repeat, we want peace. The nuclear-armed state does

not want any de-stabilisation in the region because that will have consequences beyond [the region]," he added, stressing the need for collective efforts for reforms in UN Security Council resolutions.

Saying that Israel and India were the only countries that did not abide by UN Security Council resolutions, he emphasised evolving a mechanism in the council for taking practical measures to "control the situation" if its resolutions were not acted upon and implemented.

"And that might require physical actions, physical

interventions," he mused.

PM's meetings

Meanwhile, Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif held separate meetings with Qatari Emir Sheikh Tamim bin Hamad Al Thani and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on the sidelines of the Emergency Arab-Islamic Summit convened in Doha.

In his meeting with Qatari emir, the prime minister reiterated Pakistan's strongest condemnation of the Israeli strike on a residential area in Doha on September 9 that led to the loss of precious lives

and injured several others, says a statement issued by the Prime Minister's Office.

While reaffirming Pakistan's all-out support and solidarity with Qatar at this critical time, PM Shehbaz termed Israel's attack a flagrant violation of Qatar's sovereignty and territorial integrity, as well as a serious breach of international law.

The Qatari emir expressed appreciation for the prime minister's participation in the Emergency Arab-Islamic Summit as well as for his visit to Doha on September 12 to express solidarity with Qatar at this difficult

time.

During a meeting with Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian, PM Shehbaz reiterated Pakistan's strongest condemnation of Israeli aggression against Qatar on Sept 9.

Both leaders expressed their solidarity and support for Qatar and called for unity among the ranks of the Ummah in the face of Israeli aggression.

President Pezeshkian appreciated Pakistan's strong position on the Palestine issue and expressed his desire to continue working closely with the prime minister to further strengthen Pakistan-Iran relations.

UN investigators say Israel committing genocide in Gaza

Page 11

• Independent International Commission of Inquiry asserts Israeli leadership ‘incited the commission of genocide’ • Says Netanyahu govt has betrayed Israelis, made peace ‘almost impossible’ • Tel Aviv rejects ‘bombshell’ report, calls for abolition of inquiry commission

GENEVA: United Nations investigators on Tuesday said that Israel was committing genocide in Gaza in a bid to “destroy the Palestinians”, accusing Israel’s prime minister and other top officials of incitement.

The UN Independent International Commission of Inquiry (COI), which does not speak on behalf of the world body, found that “genocide is occurring in Gaza”, commission chief Navi Pillay told *AFP*. “The responsibility lies with the State of Israel.”

The bombshell report, immediately slammed by Israel, marks the

first time a UN-mandated investigative body has concluded the country is committing genocide.

The UN itself has not labelled the situation in Gaza a genocide, but Pillay said she believed the facts presented by the commission should prompt “high-level leaders at the United Nations also to call this what it is, the genocide”.

After the report was published, UN rights chief Volker Turk said it was up to the courts to determine whether genocide was taking place, but warned: “We see the evidence mounting.”

Israel “categorically” rejected Tuesday’s report, with the foreign ministry describing it as “distorted and false” and calling “for the immediate abolition of this Commission of Inquiry”.

‘Genocidal acts’

The commission published its latest report nearly two years after the war erupted in Gaza. The report came as Israel on Tuesday launched a ground assault on Gaza City, where the UN has declared a full-blown famine.

The COI concluded that Israeli

authorities and forces had since October 2023 committed “four of the five genocidal acts” listed in the 1948 Genocide Convention.

These are “killing members of the group, causing serious bodily or mental harm to members of the group, deliberately inflicting on the group conditions of life calculated to bring about its physical destruction in whole or in part, and imposing measures intended to prevent births within the group”.

The investigators said explicit statements by Israeli civilian and military authorities and

their patterns of military action “indicated that the genocidal acts were committed with intent to destroy... Palestinians in the Gaza Strip as a group”.

They concluded that Israeli President Isaac Herzog, Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu and former defence minister Yoav Gallant have “incited the commission of genocide and that Israeli authorities have failed to take action against them to punish this incitement”.

“The responsibility for these atrocity crimes lies with Israeli authorities at the highest eche-

lons,” stated Pillay, 83, a South African former judge who once headed the international tribunal for Rwanda and also served as UN human rights chief.

Commissioner Chris Sidoti, meanwhile, stressed that the people of Israel too “have been betrayed by their government”, whose “genocidal war... has made (their) peace and security... almost impossible for the foreseeable future”.

“Their trauma and their suffering has been ruthlessly manipulated by Netanyahu and his cronies,” he told journalists.—AFP

Initial damage assessment report expected in 10 days

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- PM asks authorities to incorporate agricultural, livestock damage as well
- M-5 motorway closed, embankments to be reinforced as Sutlej threatens Jalalpur Pirwala • Two more Sehwan villages flooded as Indus in 'high flood'

By Imran Gabol

LAHORE: A committee formed by the prime minister to take stock of flood damages on Tuesday said the initial estimates will be finalised in ten days based on "accurate and transparent field reports", as PM Shehbaz Sharif separately ordered a "comprehensive assessment" of the losses.

Planning Minister Ahsan Iqbal, while chairing the meeting, stressed the importance of working in coordination with the provinces for a comprehensive assessment. The provincial representatives, however, said a final and accurate assessment would only come once the floodwaters receded, state-run APP reported.

The initial estimates of the flood damage will be finalised within the next ten days, the planning minister said, adding the verified data would be shared soon. Ahsan Iqbal said that like the 2022 floods, a comprehensive post-disaster needs assessment of damage and requirements would be carried out with the participation of international organisations.

In a separate meeting, PM Shehbaz stressed that after the assessment, the government could formulate a comprehensive rehabilitation strategy by effectively carrying out restoration efforts in the affected areas.

Federal and inter-provincial institutions should fully cooperate with each other in assessing these damages, the PM stressed. In addition to the loss of lives and properties, he emphasised that damages to crops and livestock should also be included in the assessment reports.

He suggested that assistance could be taken from the Pakistan Space and Upper Atmosphere Research Commission for satellite-based assessment, while immediate steps should be taken to protect crops from various diseases after flooding. He said that special measures should be taken for the cultivation of suitable

crops in the flood-affected areas. The prime minister was informed that damage assessment of the sugarcane, cotton and rice crops would be completed in two weeks once the water receded.

Sutlej threat to Multan district

Meanwhile, the Sutlej River continued to inundate Jalalpur Pirwala villages amid mass evacuations. As the river threatened the urban settlements of Jalalpur, the Multan district administration launched an operation to protect these neighbourhoods by building and reinforcing protective dykes along Gilani Road and Shujaabad Road. A breach on Shujaabad Road was swiftly filled using heavy machinery.

The construction of temporary embankments comes as water levels in the Chenab River recede, causing Sutlej's water to flow towards urban settlements of the tehsil.

Urban flooding linked to blocked drains, flawed city planning: Page 13

Meanwhile, the Jalalpur section of the Multan-Uch Sharif motorway was submerged at over five locations, while efforts were also ongoing to drain water from the Jalalpur Pirwala Motorway M5 Interchange and adjacent areas.

Multan Deputy Commissioner (DC) Waseem Hamid Sindhu visited Alipur, Khan Bela and adjacent embankments with a technical team and ordered the construction of temporary embankments to contain the flooded Sutlej.

Meanwhile, the evacuation of people continued in Multan and Muzaffargarh districts and Rescue 1122 teams have rescued 28,732 people and 2,998 head of cattle. As many as 9,304 people and 2,998 animals were rescued in Multan and 19,428 people from the Muzaffargarh district along the Chenab.

As many as 34 people and 14 ani-

mals were taken to safe places from Multan during the last 24 hours. The teams also evacuated 24,004 people and 4,437 animals in Jalalpur Pirwala, with 1,144 people and 607 animals during the last 24 hours.

Muzaffargarh Rescue 1122 media coordinator Mansoor Ahmad said that the rescue operation continued in the adjacent low-lying areas near the Chenab and 19,428 people were shifted to safe places. "These areas include Bait Kundrala, Mudwala, Seetpur, Sarki, Khangarh Doma, Latī Marhi, Azmatpur, Mullanwali, Kundai, Juna Bangla, Rangpur, Muradabad, Khadkan, Binda Ishaq, and Hamzaywali," he added.

Two Sehwan villages submerged

In Sindh's Sehwan, two more villages were submerged as 400,000 cusecs flowed towards Korti Barrage on the Indus. The floodwaters cut off road access to these villages, severing them from Sehwan.

Meanwhile, residents of Waryam Sehto and Aarab Otho villages were seen relocating their livestock and belongings toward safer areas using boats. However, one of the boats malfunctioned during the evacuation. Upon receiving the alert, Rescue 1122 swiftly responded and managed to rescue 35 people along with their livestock and essential household items.

According to the current situation, the water level continues to show a decreasing trend, with inflow at 609,137 cusecs and outflow at 580,927 cusecs at Guddu Barrage. At Sukkur Barrage, inflow was recorded at 571,800 cusecs, while outflow is at 518,120 cusecs. Besides, the water level showed an increase, with inflow at 300,853 cusecs and outflow at 289,098 cusecs at Kotri Barrage. According to officials, inflow was recorded at 234,755 cusecs, while outflow was at 229,905 cusecs at the Punjab head (Panjnad).

Qurban Ali Khushik in Dadu also contributed to this report

Protests threaten to overshadow Trump's controversial UK visit

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LONDON: Donald Trump's second state visit to the United Kingdom this week is shaping up to be as controversial as his first, with an imminent protest and a simmering personal feud with London mayor Sadiq Khan threatening to overshadow the carefully choreographed royal pageantry.

Mr Khan fired the opening salvo ahead of the visit, highlighting new Home Office figures showing a record number of Americans applying for UK citizenship. He attributed the surge to London's "liberal values" and diversity, remarks seen as a direct rebuke of Trump.

"Many Americans identify with our values — adherence to the rule of law, celebrating diversity, and defending minority rights," the mayor said. Earlier in the month, Mr Khan in an interview had said, "I'll show him mosques, diversity and the Notting Hill Carnival. It'll prove that multi-culturalism is our greatest strength."

The US president, who has repeatedly called Mr Khan a "stone cold loser" and accused him of presiding over rising crime in the capital, is unlikely to let the criticism pass unanswered.

Right-leaning commentators in Britain have urged restraint. Writing in the *Telegraph*, columnist Brendan O'Neill warned Mr Khan not to repeat what he described as "infantile stunts" and recalling the giant Trump Baby balloon flown over Parliament Square during the president's earlier visits. "Our relationship with America is more important than ever," he cautioned.

But protests are already planned. The Stop Trump Coalition has announced a large-scale march through London on Wednesday, the first day of the visit, when Trump will meet King Charles and PM Keir Starmer.

The demonstration comes less than a week after a far-right rally in London, addressed by former Trump adviser Elon Musk, whose warnings of violent uprising drew condemnation from Starmer.

Behind the scenes, officials are bracing for potential pitfalls. *The BBC* reports that Windsor Castle has been transformed into a "ring of steel," with 1,300 troops and 120 horses deployed to stage the ceremonial welcome and carriage procession. Palace aides have pored over banquet seating plans and menus to ensure the president feels honoured, while also preparing King Charles's speech to avoid political controversy.

Official state visits by US presidents are rare and make this week's spectacle diplomatically significant. But with protesters on the streets and a Sadiq Khan-Trump feud simmering, the risks of political theatre overshadowing substance remain high.—Correspondent



MUZAFFARGARH: Rescue officials move flood-hit people to safety.—PPI

Floods devastate India's breadbasket

GURDASPUR: The fields are full but the paddy brown and wilted, and the air thick with the stench of rotting crops and livestock — the aftermath of record monsoon rains that have devastated India's breadbasket.

In Punjab, often dubbed the country's granary, the damage is unprecedented: floods have swallowed farmlands almost the size of London and New York City combined.

India's agriculture minister said in a recent visit to the state that "the crops have been destroyed and ruined", and Indian Punjab chief minister called the deluge "one of the worst flood disasters in decades".

Old-timers agree. "The last time we saw such an all-consuming flood was in 1988," said 70-year-old Balkar Singh in the village of Shehzada, 30km north of Amritsar.

The gushing waters have reduced Singh's paddy field to marshland and opened ominous cracks in the walls of his house.

Floods and landslides are common during the June-September monsoon season on the subcontinent, but experts say climate change, coupled with poorly planned development, is increasing their frequency, severity and impact.

Punjab saw rainfall surge by almost two-thirds compared with the average rate for August, according to the national weather depart-

ment, killing at least 52 people and affecting over 400,000.

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has announced a relief package worth around \$180 million for Punjab.

'10 feet high'

The village of Toor is in tatters — strewn with collapsing crops, livestock carcasses and destroyed homes.

"The water came past midnight on August 26," said farm worker Surjan Lal.

"It rose up to at least 10 feet (three metres) in a matter of minutes," Lal said the village in Punjab's worst-affected Gurdaspur district was marooned for nearly a week.

"We were all on rooftops," he said. "We could do nothing as the water carried away everything from our animals and beds."

In adjacent Lassia, the last Indian village before the frontier, farmer Rakesh Kumar counted his losses. "In addition to the land I own, I had taken some more on lease this year," said the 37-year-old. "All my investment has just gone down the drain." To make things worse, Kumar said, the future looked bleak. He said he feared his fields would not be ready in time to sow wheat, the winter crop of choice in Punjab.

"All the muck has to first dry up and only then can the big machines

clear up the silt," he said.

Even at the best of times, bringing heavy earth-movers into the area is a tall order, as a pontoon bridge connecting it to the mainland only operates in the lean months.

For landless labourers like 50-year-old Mandeep Kaur, the uncertainty is even greater.

"We used to earn a living by working in the big landlords' fields but now they are all gone," said Kaur.

Her house was washed away by the water, forcing her to sleep in the courtyard under a tarpaulin sheet — an arrangement fraught with danger as snakes slither all over the damp land.

Basmati blues

Punjab is the largest supplier of rice and wheat to India's food security programme, which provides subsidised grain to more than 800 million people.

Analysts say this year's losses are unlikely to threaten domestic supplies thanks to large buffer stocks, but exports of premium basmati rice are expected to suffer.

"The main effect will be on basmati rice production, prices and exports because of lower output in Indian and Pakistan Punjab," said Avinash Kishore of the International Food Policy Research Institute in New Delhi. —AFP